# Sparse Prefill Prediction: Research Plan and Task List

**Status:** active, single source of truth. **Last updated:** 31 October 2026. **Supersedes:** every earlier plan, including all versions of the "Estimator Frontier" plan. Their reasoning and referee responses are kept, unedited, in `docs/archive/` for traceability; nothing in them overrides this file.

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## 0. How to use this document

**Who reads it.** The researcher, Claude chat (direction and decisions) and Claude Code (implementation). All three treat it as authoritative.

**Rules.**

1. If anything (code, an older doc, a chat message, memory) conflicts with this plan, this plan wins until it is changed. Flag the conflict; do not silently follow the other source.
2. The plan changes only by editing `docs/RESEARCH_PLAN.md` and committing. The PDF is regenerated from it in the same commit (`python tools/build_plan_pdf.py`). Never edit the PDF by hand.
3. Task status (Section 8) is updated in the same commit as the work that changes it.
4. A new decision gets a body change **and** one dated line in Appendix A. No version numbers.
5. Direction changes (gaps, hypotheses, pairings, arms, budget) are decided in Claude chat with the researcher, then written here. Claude Code implements what is written here and asks before changing scope.

**Status words.** *Done*: built, tested, used. *Built*: code and tests exist, not yet used for the study. *Partly built*: some pieces exist (named). *In progress*: started, nothing usable yet; the finished and remaining pieces are named. *Not started*. *Blocked* (reason given). *Decision*: needs the researcher.

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## 1. The question

**When does training-free block-sparse prefill actually pay end to end on a given host CPU and GPU, and can that be predicted before timing the workload there?**

- **RQ1.** Can component measurements predict end-to-end prefill time, and the sparse-versus-dense crossover, on a pairing on which the workload has not been timed? (H1, H2, H3) No timing of the workload on the target is an input to its prediction; the operation order and the estimator's selection are recorded per code path, on the target when its code path is new, with every duration discarded (Section 5.1).
- **RQ2.** Does keeping the execution order and position of each estimator's host work and synchronisations improve that prediction over aggregate models? (H1 against the KernelSight-style step form and the fitted sum; the XAttention pair, where XAttention is Xu et al., "XAttention: Block Sparse Attention with Antidiagonal Scoring", arXiv:2503.16428 (venue unconfirmed; the authors' repository cites ICML 2025); code `mit-han-lab/x-attention`, used at commit `e379887`, installed and called, with the lines listed in `docs/vendor_register.md` reproduced)
- **RQ3.** At matched per-layer recall, is accuracy the same whichever estimator chose the blocks? (H4)
- **RQ4.** Do the model's predictions, combined with the admissible density, decide whether to use sparse prefill on an unmeasured pairing better than the decision suggested by kernel speedups? (H6)

Papers report sparse attention kernel speedups on one or two machines. Our own measurements show the kernel speedup often does not survive end to end. On an A100 with our reference mask builder, prefill became slower (0.63x to 0.75x) although the sparse kernel beat PyTorch's SDPA flash kernel. How much of the builder's loop time was Python overhead depends on the instrument: about 94% under `cProfile`, which files the loop's tensor element writes under Python time, and about 53% under `torch.profiler`, which counts them as operators (development-machine profiles at 32768 tokens, not banked; T2.2 re-measures both on the target host). A vectorised builder turned the A100 result into a speedup; against the fastest correct dense kernel the speedup is smaller still, and at 8192 tokens it becomes a loss (Section 2). So host-side cost is not fixed: it

depends on how an estimator is implemented. What remains when masks are built on the GPU is host-visible work and GPU-to-CPU synchronisation. Released research code still reads GPU values from Python: XAttention runs two `assert` checks on GPU tensors per query chunk in every layer, and the FlexPrefill implementation bundled with it sizes index tensors with `.max().item()`. Compilation does not remove all of these by default: under `torch.compile` with default settings, `.item()`, `nonzero()` and an `assert` that turns a tensor into a Python bool (such as `assert not t.any()`) each break the graph, while a plain `assert` on a tensor (rewritten into `torch._assert`) and a fixed-size `topk` do not (CPU, PyTorch 2.8.0 and 2.14.1; `results/compile_graph_breaks_cpu/`, `scripts/check_compile_graph_breaks.py`). XAttention's prefill path uses the plain form (upstream commit `e379887`, `xattn/src/utils.py`), one of the two inside a `try`/`except`; the plain form did not split the graph on a CPU, and the `and` form, which splits, is on the decoding path only. Whether the compiled code still makes the GPU wait for them is measured under T2.21. Compiled arms measure what remains on the GPU (Section 5.5). Whether sparse prefill pays therefore depends on the host, the GPU, how their work overlaps, which synchronisations an implementation makes, and whether the sparse masks keep accuracy.

**Contributions, in order of weight.**

- **G2 (lead). The cost of data-dependent sparsity.** Sparse attention keeps different blocks for every input, so an implementation must read sizes or checks back to the host (a synchronisation), pad to a worst case (extra GPU work), or work in fixed-size buffers (a fixed budget). G2 is a per-operation critical-path model of the order and position, *within* a prefill step, of each estimator's data-dependent host work and GPU-to-CPU synchronisations (mask building wherever it runs, data-dependent sizing, checks that read GPU values), built only from measured components. It prices synchronising and fixed-size implementations on a given pairing; where an implementation pads, the padded work is part of its device cost. Aggregate models, including KernelSight-LM's step formula, do not represent where in a step these fall (Section 3). It predicts what each synchronisation costs on a given pairing, and so what removing it would gain, before anyone builds a fused kernel. Arms without synchronisations, including compiled arms with no wait left, are part of the test: on them the model should add nothing over simpler forms. **Not claimed as new:** the host-cost measurement method, which adapts TaxBreak's null-kernel protocol (TaxBreak uses null kernels for the launch path; we substitute them across the whole operation sequence and measure host-side compute directly at target sizes), and the queue-aware recursion, which is a standard form of host-device overlap. The adaptation is not claimed as a contribution. What is new is placing data-dependent synchronisations within the step and predicting their cost on pairings where the workload has not been timed.
- **G3 (lead).** A test of whether attention recall is an estimator-independent proxy for accuracy: at matched per-layer recall, does accuracy depend on which estimator chose the blocks? This is tested, not assumed. Prior evidence points both ways: within its own indexer, VSPrefill finds accuracy indistinguishable from full attention above 90% recall and calls recall "a faithful surrogate objective"; in decoding, Less Is More argues that which tokens are kept (a stable recency window) matters. Either outcome of H4 is reported.
- **Application: a profitability dispatcher (RQ4, H6).** For each pairing, context length and batch, the dispatcher uses the predicted time and the admissible density to choose dense or a sparse arm at a density, before the workload is timed on that pairing (Section 5.9). It is scored by regret against the best measured choice and compared with the decision suggested by kernel speedups. It answers the question a practitioner faces on a given host and GPU: should sparse prefill be switched on at all?
- **G1 (validation question).** Whether this explicit model predicts end-to-end time on real, physically distinct host-GPU pairings better than a learned predictor when only a few hardware systems are available for training. Cross-device latency prediction itself is not new (CTFusion), so G1 is not claimed as a new problem. The fitted sum (Section 5.4) is the primary comparison for G1; the learned predictor is secondary.

**Name.** The method is named BUNGA (Block-sparse Utility Navigator for GPU Attention), made of the G2 critical-path model (components defined in Section 5.1, the recursion in Section 5.4) and the profitability dispatcher (Section 5.9), while `attnbench` remains the name of the measurement harness.

**Scope.** One GPU, one CUDA stream per forward pass, batch 1 and 4, PyTorch eager and compiled. Claims do not extend to multi-GPU, continuous batching or multi-stream serving engines; the abstract states this.

**How the two halves connect.** "Profitable" (Section 5.1) needs both a speedup and non-inferior accuracy. Predicting it on an unmeasured pairing therefore needs two things: end-to-end time at a given density (G2, RQ1 and RQ2) and the lowest density at which each estimator keeps accuracy. If H4 holds, that density can be read from recall, which is cheap to measure and does not depend on the hardware; combined with the time

model, profitability on an unmeasured pairing is then predicted with no accuracy runs at all. If H4 fails, each estimator needs its own accuracy runs, and the study reports where recall falls short. Either way the result is one pipeline: predicting when sparse prefill pays (T7.6). The dispatcher (Section 5.9) turns that prediction into a decision and scores it (T7.7).

**If sparse prefill never pays.** In the pilots no deployable estimator was non-inferior at any tested density, so the profitable set may be empty on every pairing. That is stated in advance as a possible result, not a failure. The claims then are: predicted against measured end-to-end time and crossover per pairing and arm (RQ1, RQ2); which operations and synchronisations keep each arm from paying, and by how much on each pairing; whether the dispatcher avoids the losses the kernel-speedup rule would make (RQ4); and the recall result (RQ3). The paper's title would then name prediction, not profitability.

**Target.** An IEEE Transactions-level journal (TC, TPDS, TCAD or ACM TACO; open, see Section 11). Nothing here claims that bar is reached.

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## 2. What is already established (banked evidence)

These results exist and are commit-stamped. They motivate the study; they are not its confirmatory evidence.

**Earlier oracle-mask study (L4, A100, H100).**

| Finding | Evidence and caveat |
|---|---|
| Kernel speedup does not survive end to end | A100, sparsity 0.75: kernel 1.28x (8192 tokens) and 1.96x (16384) faster than PyTorch's SDPA flash kernel, measured at the model's own head layout. End-to-end prefill with the reference mask builder 0.75x and 0.63x. Flash is not the fastest correct dense kernel on that card: cuDNN SDPA takes 25.8% less time at 8192 and FA2 6.0% less at 16384 (cuDNN faults above 8192). Against them the kernel ratios are 0.95x (a loss) and 1.84x, recomputed from measured per-layer kernel times in the same sweep at the model's (12,2) head layout (`results/s7_sweep_hl122/sweep.parquet`, commit c324515). |
| The sign depends on the card | 32768 tokens, sparsity 0.75: about 1.3x on an L4, about 0.48x on an A100 with the reference builder. |
| The cause is host-side mask construction | L4 and A100 hosts share a CPU platform; builder costs within about 3%. In the reference builder, an unvectorised loop, the Python-overhead share of loop time is about 94% under `cProfile` and about 53% under `torch.profiler` (lower bound 28%: one minus operator time over unprofiled wall time); the two differ because `cProfile` counts the loop's tensor element writes, about 100,000 per build, as Python time and `torch.profiler` counts them as operators (development-machine profiles at 32768 tokens, not banked; T2.2 re-measures both on the target host). Either way this is a finding about one implementation. A vectorised builder turned the A100 result into a speedup at 16384: 1.20x against flash, an estimated 1.18x against FA2. At 8192 it reaches 1.02x against flash and an estimated 0.96x (a loss) against cuDNN. The estimates subtract 28 layers times the per-layer kernel difference from the measured dense prefill (`results/s8_vec_endtoend/vec_endtoend.parquet`, commit ae736b4); they are arithmetic, not measurements, and assume the dense prefill is GPU-bound. |
| The mechanism held on a third card | Of three predictions registered before the H100 run, two passed and one failed (7 of 9 cells). |
| The oracle is expensive | Scoring costs about 35x the latency the sparsity saves at 32768 on an L4. |
| A cheap estimator trails the oracle | Mean-pool trails the oracle by 32 to 40 points at 1.5B and 39 to 76 at 7B on multi-key retrieval at 16384. |

**Pilots on the L4, Qwen2.5-1.5B-Instruct, 1 to 3 October 2026** (called "T4 pilots" after the audit item, not the GPU).

| Finding | Evidence and caveat |
|---|---|
| Even the oracle is non-inferior only at density 0.5 | Primary claim only on qa_1/16384 (70 vs 68 of 100, bound -9.0); secondary on `niah_multivalue`/16384 (bound -7.7). Nothing at density 0.25 or 0.1. |
| Inline mean-pool is non-inferior nowhere | 7 to 24 points below dense at 0.5; estimator plus mask build cost 0.06 to 0.31 of the kernel saving. |

| Finding | Evidence and caveat |
|---|---|
| Scalar-threshold XAttention is non-inferior nowhere | At tau = 0.95, bounds -12.7 to -50.8 at densities 0.11 to 0.39; `niah_multivalue/32768` collapsed to 0 of 50, but every NIAH row at 32768 decoded past the position limit, so the collapse is confounded and is not a finding (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026). Dense reproduced 400 of 400. |
| Density depends on the prompt at fixed tau | 33% of blocks on qa_1 vs 11% on NIAH essays at 32768. |
| Estimator cost depends on the code path | On the L4's torch fallback, XAttention's estimate costs more than dense attention (19.5 vs 14.5 ms at 16384). |
| Calibrated XAttention is non-inferior on qa_1 with the authors' profiler table | T1.1 Session B, L4 torch path: qa_1/16384 69 vs 68 of 100 (bound -4.3, density 0.59) and qa_1/32768 50 vs 46 (bound -6.0, density 0.51). The table's profiling set is a RULER sample (A8). No secondary cell certifies; `niah_multivalue/32768` collapsed to 1 of 50 against 17, confounded and not a finding, since all its rows decoded past the position limit, as did 19 to 21 of 100 qa_1/32768 rows (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026). P-T4 (predicted 0 of 2 certified; 2 of 2 certified) failed. |

**Standing caveats.** Of the A100 figures against the fastest correct dense kernel, the kernel ratios are recomputed from measured kernel times and the end-to-end restatements are arithmetic, not measurements (source: the baseline-strength caveat in `docs/claims.md` dated 3 Oct 2026, on `main` since T0.16); both are to be replaced by same-session measurements (T2.16); at 32768 no faster kernel was measured at the (12,2) layout, so the A100 figures there are against flash only; some 32768-token rows exceed the position limit; results span three mask-rule eras that must not be pooled; the pilots cover one model, one card and synthetic tasks.

## 3. Gaps and nearest work

| Gap | Statement | Nearest work (read in full unless marked) |
|---|---|---|
| G1 | Learned cross-device predictors exist (CTFusion: 20 training systems, host side is input preprocessing). KernelSight-LM measures host constants per host and states that they "depend on the host CPU and serving engine, not on the GPU" (its Section 5.7), without testing it; its Section 5.5 calls them properties of the host, GPU and engine together, yet re-measures them only when the host or serving engine changes. Untested: whether an explicit critical-path model of measured components predicts data-dependent sparse prefill better than a learned predictor when few systems are available. | CTFusion, KernelSight-LM, CloserToMe; nn-Meter, HELP (abstracts only) |
| G2 | Host-overhead summaries (TaxBreak's HDBI, SKIP's TKLQT) are ratios or sums. TaxBreak splits host-visible time into framework, library and launch-path parts, and we adapt its null-kernel protocol to measure host costs (null kernels across the whole operation sequence rather than the launch path alone); it does not compose those costs in execution order with synchronisation positions, and the gap between the KernelSight-style step form (our baseline) and the recursion measures what that composition adds. (TaxBreak's remark that host cost is often shown "only as an aggregate residual" describes earlier work, not TaxBreak.) KernelSight-LM (read in full) composes within a step by one formula: the larger of GPU time plus dispatch and a term $\ell$ that the paper does not define, plus any excess of the host overlap floor over GPU time, plus a serial tail (its Section 5.7, Eq. 4); its discrete-event scheduler advances one event per batch step (Section 4.2), so nothing records where in a step a synchronisation falls, and its synchronisation term is tensor-parallel all-reduce between GPUs. Its Tier B measures host constants on the target with a short serving sweep. Serving simulators (LLMServingSim 2.0, the APEX simulator) work from per-device profiles and model no host work inside a step. TaxBreak says its replay can be imperfect for synchronisation-heavy kernels. Fused GPU kernels can remove host work and synchronisations (VSPrefill merges indices inside its kernel); released estimators often still make them. HiSparse (decode, not prefill) fuses each layer's KV-cache miss handling into one kernel inside the decode CUDA graph, which it says requires no host-side branching; it picks its cache size by profiling sweeps on each platform and finds the best setting depends mainly on host-link bandwidth. It is a system design, not a predictive model. Compilers do not remove data-dependent synchronisations by default: `torch.compile` breaks the graph at `.item()`, `nonzero()` and some forms of tensor `assert` (Section 1); whether its capture options remove the wait on the GPU is measured by the compiled arms. No lightweight model places data-dependent host work and synchronisations inside a prefill step and predicts their cost on an unmeasured pairing. | TaxBreak, SKIP/TKLQT, KernelSight-LM, LLMServingSim 2.0, APEX (Fan et al.), APEX simulator (Lin et al.), VSPrefill, HiSparse |

| Gap | Statement | Nearest work (read in full unless marked) |
|---|---|---|
| G3 | Whether recall is a sufficient accuracy proxy across estimators is untested. The Sparse Frontier lists a narrower question as unknown: "How close a recall-maximising mask is to a task-loss-optimal one" (its Limitations). VSPrefill and Less Is More compare recall across methods, not accuracy at matched recall; VSPrefill's own indexer reaches full-attention accuracy above 90% recall, while Less Is More (decoding) argues that keeping a recency window matters, so prior evidence points both ways. AB-Sparse and CompactAttention compare accuracy at fixed budgets or per-method operating points. Oracle-guided sparse prefill names recall of oracle support as a diagnostic it has not yet run. DFSAttn (video diffusion, not LLM prefill) uses the same recall definition and bounds expected recall from below by the budget times the probability that pooled block scores pick the oracle's top blocks; it compares methods at different sparsities by output similarity, not accuracy at matched recall. | VSPrefill, The Sparse Frontier, Less Is More, oracle-guided sparse prefill, AB-Sparse, CompactAttention, DFSAttn |

The full related-work list with read status is in `docs/research_brief.pdf` (the professor brief). Positioning must be re-checked in IEEE Xplore and Scopus before submission (task T7.3).

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## 4. Hypotheses

Each has a statistic and a tolerance fixed at lock (marked **[lock]**). Failures are reported as failures. Results are reported per pairing; nothing is pooled into a significance test across pairings.

| # | Hypothesis | Test and falsifier |
|---|---|---|
| H0 | **Separability.** Host components measured with one GPU equal those measured with another GPU on the same host platform; device components measured on one host equal those on another host for the same GPU. Link components are pairing-specific. | Host side: P1 vs P2, and P3 vs P5 vs P6. Device side: P1 vs P3 (L4), P4 vs P6 (H100). Per-operation differences within **[lock]**, after provider-level variance from the dense workload, compared only between pairings that share the arm's operation sequence (Section 5.1); an arm whose sequence differs is reported separately. If H0 fails, H2 is not tested and scope narrows to components measured on the target pairing. |
| H1 | **Composition.** On every confirmatory pairing (P2 to P7), the recursion over measured components predicts untraced end-to-end prefill within tolerance, and beats the fitted sum's committed prediction (the primary comparison for G1, trained only on pairings already run, Section 5.4) and also the sum, the KernelSight-style step form and the learned predictor's committed prediction (secondary). P1 is the development pairing: Gate A and the probe bounds are set on it, so its results are reported separately and never counted as a test. Stated in advance: on arms with no synchronisation inside the step (dense, mean-pool, XAttention with Python asserts removed, and compiled arms with no wait left) the recursion and the KernelSight-style step form should agree; an advantage is predicted only on arms with synchronisations. For the XAttention pair (as shipped, and with its checks removed) the recursion predicts the time difference on each pairing before it is measured. In a CPU check, the plain asserts stayed inside the compiled graph. If they also stay inside it on the GPU pairings, the compiled XAttention pair (as shipped, and with its checks removed) may show only a small gap, timed on those pairings; BUNGA's prediction of that gap on each pairing, made before it is measured, is a direct test of how it prices a wait that compilation leaves in place. | Absolute relative error within **[lock]**; sparse-vs-dense sign correct outside the resolution floor; the recursion's median absolute relative error below that of each of the fitted sum, the sum, the KernelSight-style step form and the learned predictor on each confirmatory pairing (the constant-host-cost, nearest-pairing and + s_0 baselines are reported, not scored); the retrospective leave-one-pairing-out comparison is reported as secondary; reported separately for dense, synchronisation-free and synchronising arms; the XAttention pair's predicted and measured differences agree within **[lock]** on each pairing. A large advantage on synchronisation-free arms points to a baseline bug, not support for G2. If the learned predictor wins, that is reported. |
| H2 | **Transfer.** Predictions stay within tolerance when components come from other pairings: host components for P2 (from P1) and P5 (from P3); device components for P3 (from P1); both for P6 (host from P3 and P5, device from P4). | Same statistic as H1. P6 is the full-transfer test: only its link microbenchmarks are measured before its prediction is committed. Conditional on H0. |
| H3 | **Forecast.** On P4 (a host platform used nowhere else), each estimator's crossover falls inside the grid interval predicted before P4's workload is timed. The crossover is the bracket between adjacent grid lengths where the sign of sparse minus dense time changes (Section 5.4). | Predicted grid interval vs the measured bracket, widened by the bootstrap interval of the difference at each endpoint. No crossover in range is reported as such. |

| # | Hypothesis | Test and falsifier |
|---|---|---|
| H4 | **Recall sufficiency.** At matched per-layer recall, accuracy does not depend on which estimator chose the blocks, at block sizes 32, 64 and 128. A random-selection control with no inductive bias is held to the same recall: if it matches the estimators, recall is sufficient; if it falls short, which blocks are kept matters. | Paired comparison at matched per-layer recall, or the estimator coefficient in a pre-registered model, against an equivalence bound **[lock]**. Recall is matched only by choosing among each estimator's own budget settings, never by editing masks; the share of rows that find a match is reported. Confirmatory family and multiplicity as in Section 5.7 (Holm); head type and depth thirds are exploratory. The sample size comes from a power rule fixed before lock (Section 5.7); a result below that power is reported as inconclusive. Either outcome is reported. |
| H5 | **Crossover direction (secondary).** (a) On a fixed host, a faster GPU moves the crossover to longer contexts for estimators with host-side steps (AMD: L4, L40S, H100). (b) The shift is smaller for an estimator whose selection runs entirely on the GPU. (c) On a fixed GPU, the host with lower measured host cost gives the shorter crossover. | Signs predicted from measured component ratios before data, with tolerance stated on the input ratio. Consequences of H1, reported separately. |
| H6 | **Dispatch.** On held-out pairings (P2 to P7), at 16384 and 32768 tokens (where admissibility is measured), the dispatcher's choice per context length and batch has lower regret than the kernel-speedup rule, with no more decision errors. | Regret is the measured time of the chosen configuration over the best measured admissible configuration (dense included), minus 1; mean and worst case per pairing against **[lock]**. Comparators: the kernel-speedup rule (primary), always dense, always the sparse arm with the best kernel speedup, and the best choice on the nearest measured pairing. If the mask gate fails, H6 is scored per arm (Section 5.1): the XAttention arms are removed on the new code path, and the other arms are scored. If no sparse configuration is admissible and faster anywhere, always-dense has zero regret by construction; the dispatcher can then only tie it, and the test reduces to whether it avoids the kernel-speedup rule's losses. That is reported as such. |

# 5. Method

## 5.1 Definitions

- **Unmeasured pairing.** A host-GPU pairing on which the workload has not yet been timed when the prediction is written. On the target itself the workload runs only in the structural probe (short contexts, under the profiler; for a chunked arm whose probe result is "different", once more at full length to record its structure), and, if the mask gate fails on the first card of a new code path, in an untimed mask-recording pass; every duration from all of these is discarded (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026). Allowed inputs, stated the same way for every pairing: microbenchmarks on the target (host components measured on that host without the workload on the GPU, and link and synchronisation microbenchmarks on the pairing, including bandwidth under a mask-sized CPU load; seconds); device components of that GPU; and two functional artifacts recorded per code path with every duration discarded: the operation sequence and the estimator's selection (below). No timing or trace of the composed workload on the target is an input: the claim is prediction without timing the workload on the target, from seconds of microbenchmarks there, not zero-shot prediction. The prediction file and its sha256 are synced before the timed workload starts, and the workload starts more than 60 s after the sync; a session waits 90 s (60 s plus a 30 s margin, so the store's whole-second creation time and the upload never eat the gap); the analysis allows 60 s of clock skew between the store's clock and the instance's and refuses any prediction stamped later; both numbers are `predict/commit.py`'s (Appendix A, 25 and 31 Oct 2026).
- **Host component** c_host(i): host time to issue operation i (framework dispatch, library front end, launch floor) plus host-side compute such as CPU mask building. Measured by adapting TaxBreak's null-kernel protocol, which applies null kernels to the launch path, to the whole operation sequence (device work

replaced by null kernels), and by running host-side compute directly at target sizes. The adaptation is not claimed as a contribution.

- **Device component** c_dev(i): GPU execution time of operation i, from replaying the arm's whole kernel sequence in order on the target GPU, with the masks recorded for its code path, as a CUDA graph (primary; keeps cache state between kernels and has no host gaps). Isolated per-operation replay is the cross-check, and the difference between the two is reported as the cache effect. A position the graph cannot hold as recorded (a substitution on the replay tape, such as `nonzero_static` for `nonzero`) is priced from an isolated replay of the original operator, and each position's cost source (graph or isolated) is flagged (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026). Never from a run of the composed workload: the replay contains no host, link or synchronisation cost.
- **Link component** c_link(i): pairing-dependent copy time of a non-synchronising operation i (a host-device copy the host does not wait for), from microbenchmarks on the pairing, at the loaded bandwidth where the operation sequence puts the copy alongside host-side estimator work. Synchronisations are costed separately (next item), so no physical event is charged twice.
- **Synchronisation.** Any point where the host waits for the GPU: an explicit synchronise, a copy to the host, or Python reading a GPU value (`.item()`, `bool()` of a tensor, an `assert` on a GPU tensor, sizing from `nonzero()`). Each synchronisation is one operation in the sequence and is costed once, by mechanism m: s_0(m, payload) = s_fixed(m) + payload / B. s_fixed(m) is the host cost of issuing and completing mechanism m (explicit synchronise, event synchronise, `.item()`, `bool()` of a tensor, pinned or pageable copy to the host, blocking copy from the host) with the device idle, measured at the smallest payload so it contains no transfer time (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). For `.item()` and `bool()` of a tensor the payload is zero by definition, so their s_0 is s_fixed (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). B is the copy bandwidth from the same microbenchmark as non-synchronising copies, loaded where the operation sequence puts the copy alongside host-side estimator work and unloaded otherwise, never fitted. The wait itself is never a measured constant: the recursion produces it (Section 5.4). For a synchronising operation l_i = d_i = 0. **Composite mechanisms are split:** an `assert` on a GPU tensor and sizing from `nonzero()` each become a kernel operation, with its device cost from replay, followed by a synchronisation; no operation carries both. An implicit synchronisation inside an allocator call such as `cudaFree` is not costed: it is a trace check, and a prefill trace that shows one is flagged (T2.3; Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026).
- **Operation sequence and synchronisation map.** The ordered operations of each arm, the positions and mechanisms of its GPU-to-CPU synchronisations, and the estimator's selection (its masks on each recorded prompt). Recorded per **code path**: GPU architecture, library versions, and which implementation runs (for example, XAttention's scoring uses Triton on the A100 and H100 and PyTorch elsewhere). A code path already traced is reused (the L4 PyTorch path from P1). A new code path is recorded on the target by a **structural probe**: each arm runs once at short contexts (2048 and 4096 tokens; a chunked arm at three probe lengths, each with at least two chunks) under the profiler, the order of operations and synchronisations is kept and every duration discarded, and the sequence is extended to the target length by the arm's chunking rule, checked by agreement between the short contexts. Where the result is "different", the arm's full-length structure is recorded on the target under the profiler, with every duration discarded (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026). The checker classifies each pairing and arm as "same sequence" or "different sequence" under a strict definition (primary) and a looser one (secondary, reported beside it) (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026); H0 and H2 compare components only within the same sequence under the strict definition. The strict definition compares, in order, each operation's class (its kind, with a synchronisation's mechanism and a copy's direction), its stream (by order of first use), whether the host blocks on it, and its payload class (none, or a class set by the edges in T4.1's list, proposed 8 B, 4 KiB and 1 MiB); kernel names, aten operators and layer labels are not compared. The pairings each hypothesis is scored on are listed in the lock file and printed with the lock table (Appendix A, 31 Oct 2026). The **estimator's selection** is recorded per code path at the grid lengths, untimed, since density depends on length and the short probe cannot give it. P1's masks serve the L4 PyTorch path. On P2 both XAttention code paths run on the same card through the existing `use_triton` argument (the mask gate, Section 7); masks are recorded on the target only for the first card of a new code path, and only if that gate fails (P4 is itself a new code path, Hopper with Triton: its structural probe and its mask recording run on P4, untimed, whatever the P2 gate's result). P4's recorded Triton masks are compared with P2's: if they differ, P6 records its own masks and the full-transfer claim (H2) is restated.
- **Recall.** At a layer, the share of that layer's dense attention mass, computed from its actual inputs in the arm's own forward pass, that the kept blocks capture (primary). Recall against a separate dense pass

(whose scores are already cached) is a secondary measure. H4 is read on the primary one.

- **Accuracy.** Paired non-inferiority against dense (test in Section 5.7).
- **Admissible configuration.** Dense, or an arm at a density whose accuracy is non-inferior to dense (Section 5.7). Admissibility comes from accuracy measured once on the L4 (the primary GPU, Section 5.7), or from recall if H4 holds; it is not re-measured per pairing. It is a decision input, not a confirmatory claim (Section 5.7). It transfers to a pairing on another code path only if the mask gate passes (Section 7). **Per-arm rule for H6** (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026): the restriction applies per arm, not per pairing. If the gate fails, only the arms it tests (the XAttention arms, eager and compiled, as shipped and with their checks removed) lose the L4's admissibility on the new code path. On those pairings they are removed both from the dispatcher's choices and from the best measured admissible configuration that regret is measured against, and every arm the gate does not test keeps the L4's admissibility. H6 is then still scored on P2 and P4 over the remaining arms, and the restriction is reported per pairing, naming the arms removed.
- **Kernel-speedup rule.** The decision a practitioner would make from published results: use an estimator at its admissible density wherever its sparse kernel alone beats the selected dense kernel on that GPU, ignoring estimator, host and synchronisation costs. Kernel times are device components, so the rule uses no input the model lacks.
- **Profitable.** End-to-end speedup above 1 over the fastest correct dense kernel, at non-inferior accuracy, estimator cost included. **Predicted profitability** on an unmeasured pairing combines the time model with the admissible density per estimator: from recall if H4 holds, otherwise from that estimator's accuracy runs.

## 5.2 Hardware pairings

| Pairing | Host platform | GPU | Provider | Role |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| P1 | Intel Cascade Lake | L4 | GCP G2 | Development pairing (not a confirmatory test of H1); source of transferred components |
| P2 | Intel Cascade Lake | A100 | GCP A2 | Host-side H0; host transfer (H2) |
| P4 | Intel Sapphire Rapids | H100 | GCP A3 | Held-out host platform: forecast (H3) |
| P3 | AMD EPYC 3rd gen | L4 | AWS G6 | Device-side H0; device transfer (H2) |
| P5 | AMD EPYC 3rd gen | L40S | AWS G6e | Host-side H0; host transfer; GPU-speed axis (H5a) |
| P6 | AMD EPYC 3rd gen (7R13) | H100 | AWS p5.4xlarge | Device-side H0; full transfer (H2); H5a, H5c. Run last |
| P7 (optional) | AMD EPYC 2nd gen | A10G | AWS G5 | Extra held-out point if time allows |

**Run order:** P1, P2, P4, then P3, P5, P6 and P7. Every transferred component still exists before it is used: P4 needs only its own components and its own structural probe, and P6 needs P3, P4 and P5. The GCP pairings go first because GCP sessions have a last launch date (Section 6, rule 14) and the AWS tooling (T5.1) is the likeliest delay.

**Pinned GCP machines and zones.** The machine series fixes the host platform.

| Pairing | Machine type | Zone | Why this zone |
|---|---|---|---|
| P1 | `g2-standard-8` + 1 L4 | `asia-northeast1-a` (fallback `asia-northeast1-c`) | Used by the pilots; the plan's L4 zone |
| P2 | `a2-ultragpu-1g` (A100 80GB) | `asia-southeast1-c` | The only zone offering this machine when re-verified on 16 Sep 2026; same machine as the earlier A100 evidence |
| P4 | `a3-highgpu-1g` (H100 80GB, DWS flex-start) | `us-central1-a` (fallback `asia-southeast1`) | Launch-script default; both regions priced on file |

Never an Australia region. Availability and rates are re-checked from the researcher's Mac before each session.

**Rates on 20 Oct 2026 (T0.17).** Per hour from the Cloud Billing catalogue. The USD/h and ₹/h columns are the GPU, plus vCPUs times the core rate, plus GiB of RAM times the RAM rate, with no disks. The planning rate, all-in, adds the 200 GiB balanced boot disk that each launch script creates and the local SSD that the machine

type bundles: one partition for `a2-ultragpu-1g`, two for `a3-highgpu-1g`, none for `g2-standard-8`. Disks are priced per GiB-month at the SKU for the region and provisioning model: balanced PD `16D2-FC49-A127` (`asia-southeast1`), `6AE1-525F-8B80` (`us-central1`) and `6D8C-DF09-314D` (`asia-northeast1`); local SSD `80AE-FFEA-2D34` (flex-start, `asia-southeast1`), `9F7C-3C75-F39B` (Spot, `asia-southeast1`) and `2303-1D6A-9C08` (flex-start, `us-central1`). Two inputs are assumptions, not read from the catalogue: 730 hours per month, and 375 GiB per local-SSD partition. Rupee figures are the catalogue's INR prices (₹95.99 per US dollar).

| Pairing | Model | Region | GPU SKU | Core SKU | RAM SKU | USD/h | ₹/h | Planning rate, all-in, ₹/h (USD/h) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| P2 (A100) | Flex-start | `asia-southeast1` | `293E-F9AA-0457` | `416B-7055-D3FE` | `B392-5C03-B893` | 3.0236 | 290.23 | 297.47 (3.0990) |
| P2 (A100) | Spot | `asia-southeast1` | `36BB-6DC9-2245` | `960A-A3F4-7AD1` | `7AF9-D5F3-1235` | 3.5923 | 344.82 | 350.14 (3.6477) |
| P4 (H100) | Flex-start | `us-central1` | `341A-49A5-0C07` | `9A32-36B2-7FBC` | `ED19-A584-4A84` | 4.7078 | 451.90 | 462.42 (4.8174) |
| P4 (H100) | Flex-start | `asia-southeast1` | `7CF8-F592-DE2C` | `4529-B360-744E` | `EF4B-260A-DD01` | 4.7078 | 451.90 | 463.47 (4.8284) |
| P1 (L4) | On-demand | `asia-northeast1` | `FDE8-86D4-B581` | `ECDA-3E53-7A9E` | `68F1-6598-F513` | 1.0962 | 105.23 | 108.64 (1.1318) |

Each session's cost cap (rule 10), and the rate given to the teardown script from which `docs/spend_ledger.md` is updated (rule 11), use the planning rate, all-in. On 20 Oct 2026 two places still hold September figures: the teardown script's default rate (₹80 per hour, the L4's) and the frontier budget gate's rate table on the `t11-run` branch (₹284, ₹321, ₹425 and ₹80 per hour). From 25 Oct 2026 the teardown script has no default: it refuses to run without the rate, and so does the A100 launcher.

**Funding (researcher's decision, 21 Oct 2026).** The GCP credit expires on 1 Dec 2026. New spend through 30 Nov 2026 23:59 IST has one budget of ₹14,000, counted at the planning rates above. An expense after that is approved by the researcher personally and paid outside the credit; the launch scripts say so when they run after 30 Nov 2026 (India time). Per-session caps (rule 10) are unchanged.

**AWS (researcher's decisions of 28 Oct 2026, recorded 31 Oct 2026).** Machine sizes: P3 `g6.2xlarge`, P5 `g6e.2xlarge`, P6 `p5.4xlarge`, P7 `g5.2xlarge`. On-demand only: a Spot interruption would ruin a timed run, so the launcher has no Spot path. The last AWS launch date is 20 Dec 2026, provisional. Regions, AMI, key pair and security group are not decided and have no defaults. Proposed planning rates, not yet confirmed (AWS Price List bulk API, `us-east-1` as a reference, publication 28 Oct 2026, on-demand Linux; instance plus 200 GB gp3, times 1.15, at ₹95.99 per US dollar; taxes and data transfer not included): P3 ₹110.34/h, P5 ₹249.92/h, P6 ₹761.89/h, P7 ₹136.21/h. `AWS_RATE_INR_HR` is still required at each launch. A launch's cost cap is its planning rate times its planned hours times 1.5. Spend through AWS is not part of the ₹14,000 GCP credit budget above. Tasks without a planned duration (T2.27, T3.1, T3.2, T6.1 and T6.4) are priced when they are scheduled, and any that do not fit before 30 Nov 2026 run after it. The last GCP launch date is 9 Dec 2026 (India time, inclusive; rule 14).

"Same platform" is not the same SKU: CPU model string, core count, SMT state, observed frequency, CPU microcode version, the provider's instance generation and the provisioning model (on-demand, spot, DWS flex-start or reserved) are recorded on every row (providers change hardware without notice) and compared before H0 is read.

## 5.3 Per-pairing session protocol

1. **Environment.** One container image across providers; driver matched where possible and recorded; threads pinned to the GPU's NUMA node; CPU frequency sampled; clocks locked where permitted and recorded; GPU clocks and throttle reasons sampled during every timed block.
2. **Host-speed probe** (fixed single-thread loop plus null-kernel launch burst) at the start, middle and end of the session and between ground-truth blocks.
3. **Link microbenchmarks.** Bandwidth both ways, pinned and pageable; s_fixed per synchronisation mechanism at the smallest payload, with the device idle (Section 5.1); PCIe generation and width; bandwidth under a concurrent CPU load sized like the largest mask build of any arm at each context

length; launch-queue depth Q. Then the **structural probe** for any arm whose code path has not been traced (Section 5.1); durations discarded.

4. **Host components.** Operation sequence with null kernels; CPU-side compute at target sizes.
5. **Device components.** Every arm's kernel sequence replayed in order as a CUDA graph (masks and shapes recorded per code path, Section 5.1; data-dependent work replayed with each prompt's recorded mask). Every operation also replayed in isolation as a cross-check.
6. **Prediction committed.** Computed from steps 3 to 5 (plus transferred components for H2), written with its sha256 and synced. Each prediction in the file is keyed by model, code path, arm, density, context length and batch (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026).
7. **Ground truth.** Untraced end-to-end prefill per arm, density (a set fixed at lock that includes every admissible density, so every configuration the dispatcher can choose is measured), context length and batch, arms interleaved, with a dense control. Every deployable arm's timed region includes its estimator, mask build, copies and synchronisations; the oracle arm may use cached scores, and its rows are labelled a non-deployable reference (scoring cost outside the timed path) (Appendix A, 26 Oct 2026; label corrected 27 Oct 2026). Median, p90 and p99 over repeats are reported. Every row carries its context length, batch, mask density, executed density and builder kind (`gt_schema`); a row without them is refused by the harness and by every reader. The builder kind, "cpu" or "gpu" (none for dense), is where the row's timed mask construction runs, and the harness holds the declared kind to what its probe saw in the timed blocks (Appendix A, 31 Oct 2026). **Context grid:** 2048, 4096, 8192, 16384 and 32768 tokens for every arm, balanced across arms; nothing above 32768, since the Qwen2.5 models stop there and Llama-3.1-8B does not fit at 65536 on an L4. Each cell is checked at lock against the model's position limit. **Grid rule for accuracy runs:** a cell's prompt plus its task's generation cap must be within 32,768 positions, so no row can decode past the trained positions; a cell that does not fit is sized down, never run past the limit (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026). At 32768, admissibility is taken from the accuracy cell sized to 32,768 minus the task's generation cap, while the timing cell stays at 32768; each such pair is named in T4.1's list. 2048 and 4096 are **model-validation points, not operating points**: they test the model where host work and synchronisations are the largest share of runtime, and check the structural probe's extrapolation against measured time. No profitability claim is made there, and H6 is scored only at 16384 and 32768. Timed short lengths cost like any other cell, since the structural probe discards its durations. The cell count is controlled on the arm-and-density cross, not on length: compiled variants that T2.21's graph-break report shows identical to another variant are not timed separately; the precomputed-mask ablation runs only at admissible densities and at batch 1 (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026); window and dense each run at their single density. If the budget still forces cutting lengths, the full grid stays with the XAttention pair, the compiled XAttention pair, mean-pool and dense, and other arms take 8192, 16384 and 32768.
8. **Profiler overhead.** Traced vs untraced end-to-end time per arm.

## 5.4 Cost model

For one CUDA stream, operation i has host cost h_i = c_host(i), device cost d_i = c_dev(i) (GPU execution only) and link cost l_i = c_link(i) (copy time; zero for a kernel). H_i is when the host has issued operation i; D_i is when the device finishes it.

```
H_i = H_(i-1) + h_i
if Q launches are pending:   H_i = max(H_i, D_(i-Q))          (finite launch queue, Q measured per pairing)
if operation i is a synchronisation:  H_i = max(H_i, D_(i-1)) + s_0(m_i, payload_i);  D_i = H_i   (l_i = d_i = 0)
otherwise:  D_i = max(H_i, D_(i-1)) + l_i + d_i                  (l_i at the loaded bandwidth where the operation sequence puts a copy alongside host-side estimator work)
end-to-end prefill time = D_N = H_N   (every sequence ends with a closing synchronise)
```

For a synchronisation h_i = 0: s_0 holds its whole host cost, and the recursion refuses anything else (Appendix A, 22 Oct 2026).

Only device costs transfer between hosts (H2); link and synchronisation costs are always measured on the target pairing. Copies and kernels on one stream are serialised. **Scope:** "one stream" means the GPU executes its own work in order; host and GPU still run asynchronously, and the recursion models that overlap (the host runs up to Q launches ahead of the device, and waits only at synchronisations). Every arm here

issues its GPU work on one CUDA stream, which T2.3 checks from the stream IDs in the traces. Claims do not extend to implementations that spread one forward pass over several GPU streams. Contention is costed from the loaded-bandwidth microbenchmark on the target, never fitted and never taken from the workload. It inflates only transfer terms ($l_i$, and the payload term of $s_0$), never host costs, so host-memory pressure is charged once. Each pairing's ground-truth trace is checked afterwards for copy-kernel concurrency and unified-memory faults, as a check on the model, never as an input.

**Baselines from the same components.**

- **Sum:** sum(h) + sum(l) + sum(d), no overlap.
- **Fitted sum:** a·sum(h) + b·sum(l) + c·sum(d), with a, b, c ≥ 0 fitted on the same rows as the learned baseline (see Fitting the baselines below). It uses the recursion's inputs with minimal fitting and no structure, so it is the fair test of G1 and the primary comparison: beating only LightGBM, which trains on at most six pairings, would not show that the structure helps.
- **KernelSight-style step form:** our construction from KernelSight-LM's Eq. 4, without the term $\ell$ the authors leave undefined: max(sum h, sum l + sum d) per layer, plus every synchronisation cost as a serial tail. It differs from the recursion only through operation order, synchronisation positions and the queue term, so the gap between the two isolates G2.
- **Learned (CTFusion-style LightGBM):** task features (context length, density, batch, operation and synchronisation counts), hardware microbenchmark features (host, link, device costs; pinned and pageable bandwidth) and bottleneck ratios (arithmetic intensity per operation class, host-to-device time ratio, transfer demand relative to link bandwidth, synchronisations per operation); trained as in Fitting the baselines below; features and hyperparameters fixed at lock. Tests whether the structure adds anything over regression (G1; secondary comparison). A learning curve reports its error when trained on 1 to 6 pairings, to show whether it is short of data or simply worse.
- **HDBI** reported as a diagnostic only. Its boundedness is one threshold, fitted on the training pairings by sign agreement, with ties going to the lower value, and recorded at lock (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026).
- **Constant host cost:** the recursion with every host cost replaced by one per-host constant (the median null-kernel launch cost). Tests whether per-operation host costs matter.
- **Nearest measured pairing:** the measured end-to-end time of the most similar pairing already run (same GPU if one exists, otherwise same host platform), unscaled. A naive baseline the model must beat to be worth building.

**Fitting the baselines.** The fitted sum and the learned predictor make committed predictions the same way the recursion does. Each prediction for a pairing is trained only on pairings whose ground truth was banked before that prediction is written, and it is hashed and synced with the recursion's prediction before the workload is timed (K9, T2.11). In the planned run order P2 is predicted from P1 alone and P4 from P1 and P2. The training set is whatever has been banked when the prediction is committed, and each prediction file records it. The analysis checks both directions: every pairing banked before the prediction was written is in its training set, and none banked after it is; a pairing banked within the allowed clock skew of the write is refused as unorderable (Appendix A, 31 Oct 2026). The learned predictor's committed prediction for P2 is trained on one pairing and sees no variation in its hardware features; its learning curve (T2.10) and the retrospective fits show how much this matters. These committed predictions are the ones H1 scores. Full leave-one-pairing-out fits, trained on every other pairing including those run later, are reported as a retrospective secondary analysis, labelled as such, because a forecaster could not have had the later pairings. Gate A (T3.3) stays at the sum and the KernelSight-style step form, because on P1 no other pairing exists to train a fitted baseline.

**Reported for every prediction:** absolute relative error; decision error (predicted profitable when it is not, and the reverse); crossover-length error; and a prediction interval from bootstrapping the component measurements. Errors inside the noise floor (Section 5.6) are not interpreted. A predicted tie is "not profitable" (dense) in both decision error and sign agreement; cells whose measured sparse-minus-dense difference is inside the resolution floor stay unscored by both, whether or not the sparse configuration is admissible, and are reported separately (Appendix A, 26 Oct 2026; confirmed 27 Oct 2026).

**Model ablations** (from the same components, no extra runs): the recursion without the synchronisation term; host-only (sum h) and device-only (sum l + sum d) lower bounds; the queue sensitivity below.

**Batch.** Batch 1 and 4 at 16384 on the L4 pairings; batch 4 at 32768 where memory allows on the A100 and H100. **Crossover.** Sparse is profitable where $D_N(\text{sparse}) < D_N(\text{dense})$. The crossover is reported as the

bracket between adjacent grid lengths where the sign of sparse minus dense time changes, widened by the bootstrap interval of the difference at each endpoint; the same rule is applied to predicted and to measured times. A quadratic fit $a \cdot L^2 + b \cdot L + c$ per arm is a secondary point estimate, reported with its residual (a form that fits dense well and sparse poorly is itself a finding). No crossover in range is reported as such, a location inside the resolution floor is not interpreted, and two crossovers are possible. **Crossover error:** when the predicted and the measured result have the same number of brackets, each pair is compared in order by whether the measured bracket lies inside the predicted one, whether they overlap, whether the direction of the sign change agrees, and the shift between their centres in grid steps; otherwise the result is reported as missed, spurious, a different count, or unresolved (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). **Queue sensitivity.** Every committed prediction is recomputed with Q at 0.25x, 0.5x, 2x and 4x the measured value, and with no queue term. **Density sensitivity.** Every committed prediction is also recomputed at plus and minus the measured cross-path density difference (the mask gate, Section 7; T2.28).

## 5.5 Arms

| Arm | What it does | Mask built on | Synchronisations per layer | Role |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Dense | Fastest correct kernel per card, context length and batch, chosen by the protocol below | No mask | None expected (checked in the trace, T2.3) | Reference |
| Oracle | Pools full dense-softmax attention mass to blocks, from a separate dense pass (one ranking per KV head, meaned over its query heads) | GPU (separate dense pass) | Recorded in T2.3 | Attention-mass reference; highest cost. **Not** a guaranteed quality ceiling |
| Window | Sink plus local blocks | Fixed pattern | None expected | Zero-cost floor |
| Mean-pool | Pooled query and key blocks (MInference-style); inline device builder | GPU | None (measured; `docs/claims.md`) | Cheap deployable baseline |
| Vertical-slash style | Vertical and slash scoring reduced to blocks | GPU (to be built, T1.7) | Recorded in T2.3 | Different estimator structure |
| Calibrated XAttention | Antidiagonal scoring with per-(layer, head) thresholds from the authors' profiler, run as shipped. XAttention: Xu et al., "XAttention: Block Sparse Attention with Antidiagonal Scoring", arXiv:2503.16428 (venue unconfirmed; the authors' repository cites ICML 2025); code `mit-han-lab/x-attention`, used at commit e379887, installed and called, with the lines listed in `docs/vendor_register.md` reproduced | GPU (Triton on A100 and H100, PyTorch elsewhere) | At least two per query chunk: `assert` on GPU tensors in `find_blocks_chunked` (upstream commit e379887) | Data-dependent density and synchronisations |
| XAttention, Python asserts removed | The authors' unmodified `xattn` package loaded through a module-scoped import hook that compiles only that package with `optimize=1`, which strips its Python `assert` statements and `if __debug__` blocks. Nothing is copied (rule 8), and the rest of the process, including the block-sparse package shared with mean-pool, runs unchanged. The hook compiles from source and never reads or writes the bytecode cache, so stripped bytecode cannot reach the default arm. Every session verifies that the default arm still carries its asserts and that the stripped code differs only in assert sequences and `__debug__` blocks. Triton device asserts, `TORCH_CHECK` and other C-level checks stay in place, hence the name. Whole-process `python -O` is not used (Appendix A, 12 Oct 2026). Accepted only if its masks and outputs are bitwise identical to the shipped arm on every recorded prompt | GPU | The Python assert waits removed; any left are recorded in T2.3 | Paired test of G2: same estimator and kernel, with and without synchronisations |

| Arm | What it does | Mask built on | Synchronisations per layer | Role |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Compiled variants | Dense, vertical-slash and both XAttention arms (the mean-pool compiled variant is not built, Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026) wrapped in `torch.compile` (mode `reduce-overhead`, which uses CUDA graphs where the graph allows), with default settings and again with the capture options for scalar outputs and data-dependent shapes. The authors' code is wrapped, not edited (rule 8). Compile time and warm-up are excluded from timed runs and reported separately. Masks are compared with the eager arm on every recorded prompt; a variant whose masks differ on any prompt is reported as a different arm, with the agreement share | As the eager arm | Graph breaks per layer recorded on CPU (T2.21); waits that remain recorded on the GPU (T2.3) | Tests whether compilation removes the synchronisations G2 prices. Each compiled variant is its own code path (K8), never pooled with eager |
| DuoAttention-style (conditional) | Retrieval heads dense, streaming heads sink plus local, from released head patterns; only if patterns exist for a study model and the licence allows | Fixed per head | None expected | Head-differentiated recall profile for H4 |
| Precomputed-mask (ablation) | Each estimator's masks computed offline and preloaded; then the same kernel | Preloaded | None | Separates estimator compute and synchronisation from kernel and launch cost |
| Random at matched recall (H4 control) | For each layer, blocks drawn uniformly at random (fixed, recorded seeds) and added until the layer's recall reaches the target, with the same mandatory blocks as every arm; untimed | Offline | Not timed | No inductive bias: tests whether recall alone carries accuracy. Its density is reported, since it will need more blocks |

All arms use one per-head selector and one block-sparse kernel. A bitwise gate requires the selector to reproduce the head-uniform rule exactly when heads share scores. Timed block size is 128. Every row records mask density, executed density and `sys.flags.optimize` (under K8 an interpreter flag is a distinct code path).

**Dense-baseline selection (control K2).** Candidates: SDPA flash, SDPA cuDNN, SDPA memory-efficient, FA2, and FA3 on the H100. A candidate is *correct* if it matches the float64 naive reference of `attnbench/gates.py` on fixed inputs within a tolerance fixed at lock, or, where that reference cannot be allocated, passes the gate's cross-backend comparison (weaker evidence), and runs N repeats without a device fault. Which of the two each cell used is named per cell (cuDNN faulted above 8192 tokens on the L4 and A100). The *fastest* correct candidate has the lowest median untraced time per card, context length and batch, measured in a warm-up block separate from ground truth. The choice is recorded before the timed runs, and every speedup is stated against it. Banked A100 figures are restated against it (Section 2).

## 5.6 Confounders and controls

| Confounder | Control |
|---|---|
| CPU microarchitecture, caches, memory bandwidth | Inside c_host, measured on the target host at target sizes; never synthesised |
| PCIe generation, copy and sync latency | c_link measured per pairing; generation and width recorded |
| Cloud CPU frequency (governor and true clock often hidden) | Host-speed probe distributions per session; a session is usable only if the probe's coefficient of variation is under a bound; a component transfers only if source and target probe medians differ by less than a bound. Both bounds fixed at lock from P1 repeat sessions. Failing sessions are rerun |
| vCPU topology, SMT, noisy neighbours | Pinning; topology and tenancy recorded; probe detects drift; P1 repeat sessions give the between-session floor |

| Confounder | Control |
|---|---|
| Host-memory contention between mask building and DMA | Link bandwidth also measured under mask-sized CPU load; copies in flight during host-side estimator work are costed at the loaded bandwidth |
| Driver and software differences | One container image; driver recorded. H0 compares components only between sessions with the same driver version; where versions differ, the comparison is reported as confounded. Dense control every session |
| Operation sequence differs by GPU or library | Sequence recorded per code path (Section 5.1); H0 and H2 only within the same sequence |
| Cloud noise floor | Between-session spread of end-to-end time from the P1 repeat sessions (T3.2), and each pairing's within-session spread, reported as numbers; prediction errors inside them are not interpreted. The resolution floor and the noise floor are fixed at lock from the measured run-to-run spread (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). A bare-metal control is out of budget and the claims concern cloud hosts; this is stated as a limitation |
| Dense kernel choice | Selection protocol (K2, Section 5.5); speedups stated only against the selected kernel. The selected kernel's time in every timed block is compared with its warm-up time; a drift beyond the resolution floor flags the block |
| GPU cache state between kernels | Device time from in-order graph replay; isolated replay as the cross-check, difference reported |
| GPU clock throttling | Clocks and throttle reasons sampled in every timed block; throttled blocks flagged and rerun |
| Measurement asymmetry between arms | One device-time method (in-order graph replay) for all arms; isolated replay only as a cross-check |
| Prediction made trivial | No prediction input comes from the composed workload on the predicted pairing |
| Profiler overhead | Ground truth from untraced runs |
| Compilation | Compile time, warm-up and recompiles excluded from timed runs; recompile count recorded per block, and a recompile inside a timed block flags it |
| Predictions fitted after the fact (K9) | Predictions hashed and synced before the workload runs |
| NUMA placement | Threads pinned to the GPU's local node; microbenchmarks from that node |
| Pinned vs pageable memory | Both measured; each traced copy classified and costed |
| Launch-queue backpressure | Q measured per pairing; host costs measured in bursts |
| Unified memory | Not used; any fault flags the row |
| Code-path mask divergence (XAttention scores with Triton on the A100 and H100, PyTorch elsewhere) | Mask gate on P2 (both paths on one card through `use_triton`) and the P4 against P2 Triton comparison (Section 7); per-layer mask agreement and density difference reported; density sensitivity on every prediction (Section 5.4); admissibility transfers across code paths only if the gate passes (Section 5.1) |
| Interpreter flags | `sys.flags.optimize` recorded on every row; a different flag is a different code path (K8) |
| Replay mismatch | Replayed kernel names and durations compared with the P1 trace per operation family before H1 is read; mismatched variants flagged |
| Null-kernel floor plausibility | P4's floor reported with its exact definition and compared only with a published figure measured the same way, named with its tool: TaxBreak, 4.7 us, the mean null-kernel launch floor from an `nsys` null-kernel run on a Xeon 8480C with an H100 in a DGX H100 (its Table III); SKIP, the PyTorch-Profiler-based profiler of Vellaisamy et al. (ISPASS 2025), 2.37 us, null-kernel CUDA launch-API overhead on a Xeon Platinum 8468V with an H100 PCIe (its Table V) |

**Study controls K1 to K9.** K1 one selector and kernel for every arm, Partly built (head-uniform selector and kernel built; per-head selector built, on `main` since T0.16); K2 fastest correct dense baseline per card, context length and batch (protocol in Section 5.5; Partly built, T2.16); K3 disjoint calibration splits with a pre-run gate (built); K4 three models, Qwen2.5-1.5B, Qwen2.5-7B, Llama-3.1-8B held out of all fitting (planned); K5 recall at block sizes 16 to 128 at matched density (control only; AB-Sparse already reports the decode-side version); K6 pre-registration, checks that fail on purpose, provenance on every row (in place); K7 cells count only if dense accuracy clears a floor (not built); K8 code path recorded per row, fallbacks never on the same curve (built); K9 predictions hashed before the workload (Built, T2.11).

### 5.7 Quality measures

- **Accuracy test (pre-registered):** exact paired non-inferiority, one-sided alpha 0.025, as used in the pilots: a union bound over one-sided Clopper-Pearson bounds on the two discordant cells (`attnbench/analysis/exact_noninferiority.py`). The dense arm must reproduce exactly in every run on the same card.
- **Primary accuracy statement:** the achieved one-sided lower confidence bound on the paired accuracy difference, in points, reported continuously. The margin is used only to produce the admissibility label the dispatcher consumes: 10 points primary, with sensitivity at 5 points. No 2-point column: with no discordant pairs the union bound's floor is 4.3 points at n = 100 and 2.2 at n = 200, and about 220 examples are needed for 2 points. Absolute and relative differences are both reported (K7).
- **Margin against speedup:** for each margin and configuration, whether it is admissible and the speedup it buys, reported as a frontier from the same accuracy rows (no GPU cost).
- **Primary cell size:** `qa_1`/16384 is sized once at n = max(200, the H4 power rule), so the same rows serve admissibility and H4. At 200 the 5-point label is reachable at moderate discordance. Secondary cells keep the 10-point margin, stated as such. Admissibility n is fixed at lock.
- **Admissibility family:** admissibility is a decision input, not a confirmatory claim. Its Holm family is declared at lock as every admissibility test that feeds the dispatcher. Correcting shrinks the admissible set, which can move regret either way, so dispatcher regret is reported with and without the correction.
- **Replacement test:** a more powerful paired test is adopted only if simulation shows coverage at or above nominal across dense accuracies including the near-ceiling region and across the pilots' discordance rates, with power secondary among tests that pass coverage. The choice is recorded in the lock commit. Candidates are leads only until read in full (rule 5).
- **Recall:** both references (Section 5.1), per layer, on the very masks that produced each accuracy row; also by head type (retrieval-like vs local, criterion fixed at lock) and by depth third.
- **Intrinsic recall:** budgets 0.50, 0.25, 0.10, 0.05; null scorer as a floor; budget selection on 32 examples per task.
- **H4 across block sizes:** on the primary cell (`qa_1`/16384; n as in the primary cell size above), block sizes 32, 64 and 128 through an untimed reference masked-attention path; block 16 only if that path supports it.
- **Recall matching:** an estimator reaches a target recall only through its own budget settings (threshold, top-k or density), never by editing its masks. The share of rows that find a match is reported.
- **H4 equivalence bound:** justified at lock from the tasks (how large an accuracy difference would change which estimator a practitioner picks). The default is 10 points; T1.5 also prices a 5-point bound, which needs about four times the examples.
- **H4 power rule (fixed at lock):** $n \approx (z(1-\alpha) + z(1-\beta/2))^2 \times p / \delta^2$, where p is the rate at which two estimators disagree on an example (measured on the banked pilot rows, T1.5), δ is the equivalence bound, α is the one-sided level for each of the two tests and 1-β is the power, all fixed at lock, with α adjusted by Holm across the confirmatory family. p is the upper 95% confidence bound of the pilot disagreement rate, not its point estimate. At $\alpha = 0.025$, 90% power and $\delta = 10$ points this is about 1,300 × p (130 at 10% disagreement, 260 at 20%). Bonferroni over three comparisons gives about 1,630 × p, and Holm needs no more than Bonferroni; the family size, and so n, is fixed at lock. The exact test needs more.
- **H4 confirmatory family:** the planned estimator pairs at block sizes 32, 64 and 128 on the primary cell, plus the random-selection control against each estimator, Holm-corrected together. Head type and depth thirds are exploratory and spend no α. An H4 result below the fixed power is reported as inconclusive, never as support or refutation.
- **Where measured:** once, on the L4 (the primary GPU), with the dense control repeated on the A100. The cross-card control's acceptance criterion is a task-score bound fixed at lock, with the exact-match rate reported alongside; bitwise reproduction across cards is not expected.
- **Position limit:** every accuracy run follows the grid rule in Section 5.3 step 7 (prompt plus generation cap within 32,768 positions). Banked 32768 rows that broke it are confounded: every NIAH row at 32768 and about a fifth of `qa_1` rows there decoded past the limit (`docs/t4_xattention_calibrated.md`), so the `niah_multivalue`/32768 collapse is not a finding (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026).
- **Dense floor (K7)** and **critical density** (lowest non-inferior oracle density; descriptive only).

### 5.8 Extension: chunked prefill

On P5, with inline mean-pool and calibrated XAttention, prefill also runs in chunks of 2048 and 4096 tokens at 16384 and 32768. Each chunk reruns the estimator over the accumulated keys, which the recursion represents as repeated operations; the predicted re-selection overhead is committed first. First check whether the block-sparse kernel supports query chunks shorter than the key length; if not, drop the extension and record it. The kernel's time at each query-to-key ratio is recorded separately from the per-chunk estimator operations, and mask density separately from executed density. This reruns the estimator per chunk and is not presented as state-of-the-art chunked-prefill engineering. External reference only: CompactAttention reports XAttention at 0.68x to 0.84x of dense speed end to end under chunked prefill on two GPUs.

### 5.9 Application: profitability dispatcher

**What it decides.** For each pairing, context length and batch, one configuration: dense, or a sparse arm (eager or compiled) at one of its admissible densities. It picks the admissible configuration with the shortest predicted end-to-end time, and dense unless a sparse configuration is predicted faster by more than the resolution floor.

**Inputs.** Only what a prediction may use on an unmeasured pairing (Section 5.1), plus admissibility. The choice is written into the same hashed prediction file as the time prediction, before the workload runs (K9).

**Scoring.** On each held-out pairing, from the measured ground-truth grid (Section 5.3, step 7), so it needs no extra GPU sessions: regret (H6), decision errors (sparse chosen where dense was faster, and the reverse), and time gained or lost against always-dense.

**Comparators.** The kernel-speedup rule (Section 5.1; primary), always dense, always the sparse arm with the best kernel speedup, and the best measured choice on the nearest measured pairing.

**Scope.** An offline decision per pairing, context length and batch, not a runtime scheduler that reacts to live load (Section 10).

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## 6. Operating rules (both Claudes, every session)

**Claims and evidence**

1. Never claim "no accuracy loss" or "zero accuracy cost". Report non-inferiority at a stated margin.
2. Keep oracle, deployable-estimator, CPU-builder and GPU-builder results distinct; never put them on one curve.
3. Every measurement is commit-stamped with `git_dirty = False`; results from different mask-rule eras or code paths are never pooled.
4. Never delete or rewrite historical audit findings. Withdrawn or corrected items are annotated in place.
5. Cite only papers read in full; anything else is marked "from abstract". If a paper is needed and not available, ask the researcher for the PDF instead of characterising it from search summaries.
6. Predictions are written and hashed before the data they predict.

**Code**

7. Run the focused tests for anything changed before committing; keep the full suite green.
8. Do not commit unrelated changes. Third-party code is installed and called, never copied, except as listed in `docs/vendor_register.md`. Each entry names the upstream, the commit, the licence, which lines are verbatim or adapted, the licence and notice that travel with it, why it cannot be installed and called, and the date the researcher approved it. Code from a repository with no licence is never vendored. Its lines are reproduced only where `docs/vendor_register.md` lists them and the researcher's approval is recorded in `docs/permission_log.md`.
9. No model identifiers or assistant attribution in research artifacts beyond the commit trailers the tooling adds.

**Cloud sessions (GCP now, AWS later)**

10. Before any GPU session, state the exact command, estimated cost, cost cap, hard-delete limit and artifact path, and wait for approval. The researcher runs all cloud commands from their Mac.

11. Launch sequence: cleanup check, cost cap, hard-delete limit, stale-results quarantine, deploy the clean commit, preflight, the GCS write gate (`scripts/gcp_verify_gcs_writable.sh`), the bootstrap of a fresh instance (`scripts/gcp_bootstrap_instance.sh`), run, teardown through the teardown script (which writes `session_cost.txt`). Update `docs/spend_ledger.md` from that file.
12. L4 zone `asia-northeast1-a` (fallback zones as in Section 5.2). Never an Australia region, on GCP (`australia-*`) or on AWS (`ap-southeast-2*`, `ap-southeast-4*`); `scripts/_launch_policy.sh` and `scripts/_aws_launch_policy.sh` refuse both.
13. AWS sessions only after the AWS tooling meets the same guarantees and passes tests against a fake CLI (task T5.1). The last AWS launch date is 20 Dec 2026 (India time, inclusive; provisional, proposed and not yet confirmed), set in one line in `scripts/_aws_launch_policy.sh`; the date is a last day, not a go-ahead. AWS sessions are on-demand only. Each AWS launch's cost cap is its planning rate times its planned hours times 1.5.
14. No GCP session launches after **9 December 2026** (India time; the date itself is allowed). The launch scripts refuse later launches (`scripts/_launch_policy.sh`). GCP work (T2.27, T3.1, T3.2, T6.1, T6.4) is planned to finish before then.

**Permissions**

15. Any use of results that needs the researcher's permission is recorded in `docs/permission_log.md` before the use. A use not in the log is not approved.
16. Any push or merge needs the researcher's explicit yes to that exact action, naming files, branch and destination, recorded in `docs/permission_log.md` before acting (Appendix A, 21 Oct 2026).

**Writing for the professor:** plain language, short sentences, no em dashes.

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## 7. Decision gates

| Gate | Condition | If it fails |
|---|---|---|
| Gate A: P1 | The recursion beats the sum and the KernelSight-style step form on P1 (T3.3); P1's replay-versus-trace difference per operation family is within a bound fixed at lock; and the delay-injection slope check passes: each synchronisation mechanism is injected separately into the dense arm on the L4, where the GPU is busy and where it is idle, and the ratio of predicted to measured time per injected synchronisation is within a bound of 1.0 fixed at lock, one slope per mechanism (double counting gives about 2; an instrument check, Section 10). The replay-versus-trace check reruns on the first card of every new code path before H1 is read there | Stop; revise the model, the synchronisation costing, or the device-cost method if the replay check failed, before any new pairing |
| Mask gate: P2 | On P2, XAttention's Triton and PyTorch paths run on the same recorded prompts through `use_triton`; per-layer mask agreement and density difference against P1's recorded masks are within a bound fixed at lock. P4's Triton masks are then compared with P2's | Masks are recorded on the target, untimed, for the first card of the new code path; the XAttention arms' admissibility does not transfer to that code path, and other arms keep theirs (per-arm rule, Section 5.1). If P4 and P2 differ, P6 records its own masks and the full-transfer claim is restated |
| Null-kernel floor | P4's null-kernel launch floor is within a fixed multiple (set at lock) of the published figures measured the same way (Section 5.6) | Investigate and report before H3 is read; H3 is read only with the cause stated |
| Gate B: lock | All **[lock]** values fixed, two adversarial reads done, lock commit tagged (T4.x) | No confirmatory pairing runs |
| Gate C: AWS | AWS tooling passes fake-CLI tests; quotas granted; each pairing costed | No AWS launch |
| Gate D: H0 | Separability holds | H2 not tested; scope narrows to per-pairing composition |
| Last GCP launch | Every GCP session launches by 9 Dec 2026 | No GCP launch after the date; re-plan the remaining GCP work with the researcher |

| Gate | Condition | If it fails |
|---|---|---|
| Budget | Each session within its cap | Cut in an order fixed at lock (proposed: P7 first, then the chunked extension); the cut order never removes ground-truth timing, H1 or H4 |

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## 8. Task list

Owner: **Code** = Claude Code, **Chat** = Claude chat with the researcher, **R** = researcher. IDs are permanent; do not renumber. Add new tasks at the end of a phase.

### Phase 0: Repository transition

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T0.1 | Commit this plan, its PDF, `CLAUDE.md` and the build tool | Code | | On `main` | Done (merged to `main` 4 Oct 2026) |
| T0.2 | Brief Claude chat: upload the PDF to the project, remove superseded plan PDFs, paste the handover note | R | T0.1 | Chat answers a test question from the plan correctly | Done (4 Oct 2026) |
| T0.3 | Tag the pre-pivot state (`pre-pivot-2026-10-04`) so every banked result stays reproducible | Code (R approves push) | | Tag on origin | Done (18 Oct 2026): `pre-pivot-2026-10-04` confirmed on origin at `7bf2a01` (`git ls-remote --tags`) |
| T0.4 | Review `docs/code_inventory.md`: confirm keep / adapt / archive for every module and script | R + Chat decide; Code verifies by reading the code | T0.1 | Every row has a confirmed decision | Done (4 Oct 2026; "Check" rows are resolved by reading the code during T0.5) |
| T0.5 | Move archived code and its tests to `legacy/` (not deleted), fix imports, keep the suite green | Code | T0.3, T0.4 | Suite green; no live module imports `legacy/` | Not started |
| T0.6 | Move superseded docs to `docs/archive/` unchanged; update test references to their paths | Code | T0.3 | Suite green | Not started |
| T0.7 | Rewrite `README.md` for the new question; remove claims that break rule 1 | Code | T0.1 | README matches Sections 1 and 2 | Done (19 Oct 2026): README on main; rewritten for public readers |
| T0.8 | Point `.github/copilot-instructions.md` at this plan | Code | T0.1 | Done | Not started |

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T0.9 | Carried-over housekeeping: `ledger-updates` work at `dc707e3` (cherry-pick of the local-only `b00019f`), spend ledger brought up to date, audit addenda | Code | | Confirmed with R and done | Decision (scope to confirm). On 18 Oct 2026 the sessions table in `docs/spend_ledger.md` had no row for 15 sessions that have a `session_cost.txt`: the seven Stage 2 segments of 4 Sep 2026 (one now under `results/_discarded/`), segment 3 of 5 Sep, Stage 5b of 7 Sep, and six T4 sessions of 1 and 2 Oct (dense probe, selected pilot, sparse canary, 32768 sparse pilot, XAttention canary, XAttention pilot). The 32768 pilot's cost file is pasted below the table, and `dc707e3` (cherry-pick of the local-only `b00019f`) pastes the two XAttention ones; none is a table row. The 2 Oct 16384 sparse pilot session has no cost file |
| T0.10 | Archive the last Estimator Frontier plan (with referee responses) and the professor brief in `docs/archive/` and `docs/` | Code | T0.1 | Files committed | Done |
| T0.11 | Bring the GCP launch scripts in line with the plan: pinned default zones, refusal of Australia regions and of launches after the last GCP launch date; re-check rates | Code | | Tests pass; rates confirmed by R | Partly built (zones and refusals done and tested; rate re-check done through T0.17, 20 Oct 2026) |
| T0.12 | Find the source of the caveat "some A100 dense baselines were estimated"; keep it with its source, or drop it with a dated note | Code | | Recorded here | Done (5 Oct 2026): the baseline-strength caveat in `docs/claims.md` (3 Oct 2026) on branch `frontier-prereg-2026-10-03`; figures carried into Section 2; on `main` since T0.16 (21 Oct 2026) |
| T0.13 | Keep the professor brief's source in the repo (`docs/brief/`) with a build script | Code | | Brief rebuilt from source | Done |
| T0.14 | Check every related-work entry not read in full against its abstract; rewrite any description taken from a search summary | Chat (R supplies abstracts or PDFs) | | Each entry marked "read in full" or "from abstract" | Not started |
| T0.15 | Retire the earlier Claude Doc and point it at this plan | Code | | Doc shows only the retirement notice and links | Done |
| T0.16 | Decide what happens to branch `frontier-prereg-2026-10-03` (34 unmerged commits: the A100 baseline caveat, audit annotations, the recall pass, the per-head selector, Llama fixes, the superseded pre-registration and its budget gate) | R decides; Code carries out | | Decision recorded and carried out | Done (21 Oct 2026; researcher's decision, option 2): the branch was merged at 459c892 with a merge commit, so every hash it cites stays reachable, then pruned. On `main`: the caveats and audit annotations, the era register and per-head selector, the Llama fixes, the recall pass, splits and kernels, and T1.1's amendments A1 to A9. In `docs/archive/`: the superseded pre-registration, the rest of `frontier_prereg.py`, its plan test and the budget gate. The GPU launchers carry no frontier gate. The README count commits were dropped, and the 16 commits that exist only on the local branch were not included |

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T0.17 | GCP quota and availability for `a2-ultragpu-1g` (P2, `asia-southeast1-c`) and `a3-highgpu-1g` (P4, `us-central1-a`, fallback `asia-southeast1`) in the pinned zones, from the Cloud Quotas API; whether `scripts/_launch_policy.sh` counts a DWS flex-start request or the VM start as the launch; a re-check of both rates (A100 last pinned 16 Sep 2026, H100 15 Sep 2026; this is also T0.11's open rate re-check for P2 and P4); and the flex-start queue wait. Google's flex-start documentation says `--request-valid-for-duration` sets the maximum wait for capacity: 90 seconds to two hours for a VM in one zone, zero for a VM that may take any zone in the region. The launch scripts do not pass that flag, so the wait they get is not stated | Code prepares the commands; R runs them | | Quota and availability per pinned zone, both rates, the launch definition and the queue wait recorded here | Done (20 Oct 2026). Quotas: preemptible A100 80GB 1 and A2 CPUs 12 in `asia-southeast1`; preemptible H100 1 in `us-central1` and `asia-southeast1`; preemptible CPUs 26 in both regions (requested 12 to 26 and 0 to 26, both granted); GPUs across all regions 1 (a request for 2 was denied); CPUs across all regions 32; the H100 GPU-family quota returned no value. Past refusals named `PREEMPTIBLE_NVIDIA_A100_80GB_GPUS` for flex-start and Spot A100 requests, and `GPUS_PER_GPU_FAMILY` for flex-start H100 requests. Availability: every pinned machine type and GPU is offered in its pinned zone, and every zone checked was up; in the P4 fallback region `a3-highgpu-1g` is offered in `asia-southeast1-b` and `-c` only. Rates with SKU IDs: Section 5.2. Queue wait: the launch scripts pass no `--request-valid-for-duration`; past flex-start creates completed in 35 to 143 s, and refusals for lack of capacity came after 72 to 139 s. Delete timing: `--max-run-duration` counts from when the VM enters RUNNING, not from the request. Launch definition (researcher's decision, 21 Oct 2026): every `gcloud compute instances create` request, retries and the Spot fallback included, must be submitted by the end of 9 Dec 2026 IST (moved from 22 Nov 2026 on 21 Oct 2026), scripts that retry check the date again before every attempt and stop at the boundary, and a request that waits for capacity counts as launched when it is submitted |

## Phase 1: Quality evidence (G3) on existing infrastructure

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T1.1 | Run calibrated XAttention sessions A and B as pre-registered (`docs/t4_xattention_calibrated.md`); GCP, launch by 9 Dec 2026 | Code prepares; R runs | | Rows banked, analysis written | Done (25 Oct 2026). Session A done (22 Oct 2026, A100 Flex Start, 55 min, ₹273): the `authors`, `authors_full` and `ruler_heldout` tables are in `configs/xattn_thresholds/`, made at `9c39048` on the Triton path. Session B done (25 Oct 2026, L4 on-demand, 210 min, ₹380): dense and the three tables, 400 rows each at `c0d9358`; the `authors` table certifies both primary `qa_1` cells, so P-T4 failed; R1 to R4 not scored (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026); the results section is in the phase document named in this row. Amendments A1 to A9 and the calibration-script changes on `main` since T0.16; A6 carries a dated note that its replication link points to an archived study. The XAttention rows at `c0d9358` carry the earlier timed-region fingerprint of the XAttention backend (one shared cumulative-length tensor); from 27 Oct 2026 the backend builds the three tensors as upstream does, with bitwise identical outputs (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026) |
| T1.2 | Recall with both references, per layer, by head type and depth third, on accuracy rows | Code | | Tested on CPU fixtures; GPU check at 16384 | Partly built (intrinsic recall pass exists, on `main` since T0.16) |
| T1.3 | Fix the head-type criterion (retrieval-like vs local) | Chat decides; Code implements | | Criterion in code and here | Decision |
| T1.4 | Wire the reference masked path (`backends/block_masked.py`) into H4 runs at block sizes 32 and 64 | Code | | Accuracy rows at 32, 64, 128 on a dry run | Partly built |
| T1.5 | H4 dry analysis on banked pilot rows plus recall (exploratory, not confirmatory); measure the estimator disagreement rate for the H4 power rule; price n at 10-point and 5-point bounds | Code | T1.2 | Report written, marked exploratory | Not started |
| T1.6 | Cost the real-text haystack swap on the primary model; decide | Code costs; R decides | | Decision recorded | Not started |
| T1.7 | Build the window and vertical-slash arms; check DuoAttention patterns and licence | Code | | Arms pass the selector gate | Not started |
| T1.8 | Recall matching through each estimator's own budget settings; match-coverage report | Code | T1.2 | Tested on CPU fixtures | Not started |
| T1.9 | Random-selection control at matched recall for H4: per-layer random blocks to the target recall, seeds recorded, density reported | Code | T1.8 | Tested on CPU fixtures | Not started |

## Phase 2: Component measurement and the model

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T2.1 | Host-speed probe (single-thread loop + null-kernel burst), adapting `scripts/host_cpu_probe.py` | Code | | Runs on CPU; GPU path dry-run tested | Done (25 Oct 2026): `host_speed.py` in `attnbench/components/`, run by `host_cpu_probe.py speed`. A fixed pure-Python loop, then bursts of the null kernel `torch.cuda._sleep(0)` timed launch by launch, with the device synchronised outside the timer before each burst; CPU clock and steal over the probe; one provenance-stamped row per tag, and a tag is never reused. Runs on CPU; the GPU path is dry-run tested with fakes. The session and transfer bounds are set at lock (T3.2, T4.1) |

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T2.2 | Null-kernel host-component profiler (adapting TaxBreak's protocol to the whole operation sequence); also profiles the reference mask builder on the target host and banks the profile, under both instruments, replacing the unbanked figures in Sections 1 and 2 (Appendix A, 19 and 27 Oct 2026) | Code | T2.3 | Unit-tested; L4 smoke run | Partly built (27 Oct 2026): `host_profile.py` and `builder_profile.py` in `attnbench/components/`, the second run by `profile_reference_builder.py` in `scripts/`. **The null pass** runs the arm's prefill from the tape (T2.4, so it waits for nothing and takes the recorded path) with a dispatch mode that replaces each aten call that launches device work by one null kernel (`torch.cuda._sleep(0)`, T2.1's) and an output allocated at the shape the call would give, and replaces the block-sparse entry point the same way. Per launching call it times the gap (the arm's Python and the dispatcher since the previous call) and the launch; calls that launch nothing run for real; host-compute regions are timed directly and taken out of the gap, so they are charged once. Costs go to recorded positions by runs of one aten operator in one layer: the first operation of a call carries gap + launch and each further one a median null launch, and a run that is not a multiple of the launching calls, an entry that was not nulled, a call out of order, a surplus call, a marker count that differs and a CUDA-graph launch are all refused (`ProfileMismatch`), so no cost goes to a different sequence. The profile is the per-position median over repetitions with every repetition kept (for T2.19's bootstrap), and `host_costs` is `to_operations`' `host` argument. Tested on CPU with a scripted clock, hand-computed, with a mutant for each guard. **The reference builder** is profiled on the host it runs on, by two instruments banked side by side, because they disagree: `cProfile` does not count a tensor `__setitem__` or `__getitem__` (a type slot) as a call, so the builder's ~100,000 aten calls per build at 32768 land in its own time, while `torch.profiler` sees them as operators. A development run on a Mac (not the target host, not banked) gave `cProfile` 94.2% at 32768 (0.374 s of 0.397 s per 10 calls, the plan's figure to the digit), `torch.profiler` 0.53 and a lower bound of 0.28 (one minus its operator time over the unprofiled wall time); a loop of tensor slot writes reads 1.00 and 0.51. So the plan's "about 94% is Python overhead" holds under `cProfile` and does not under `torch.profiler`, and the 19 Oct 2026 line does not say which instrument it was. Decided by the researcher (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026): Sections 1 and 2 state the share per instrument, `cProfile` and `torch.profiler`, and the builder is profiled at density 0.5, the script's default. Not done: the L4 smoke run, and the arm runners that supply `run_prefill`, the tape and the recording (T2.27 step 1); a Triton entry point is not nulled yet (XAttention on the A100 and H100), and a compiled arm's graph launch is refused (T2.21). Known limits of the instrument, to be checked on the L4: the tape's `TorchFunctionMode` adds a little to a gap that a real run does not have, and the replaced call skips the kernel's C++ front |

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| | | | | | end, so a gap can be a little long and a launch a little short; when the calls of one run launch different numbers of kernels the cost is spread evenly inside the run. Shakedown 2's `t22` (28 Oct 2026, built, not run) takes the null-kernel profile of mean-pool's prefill from its tape on the L4 host, profiles the reference builder under both instruments there, and reads the 32768 row against the 94% |
| T2.3 | Operation sequence and synchronisation map per code path, with the GPU stream IDs used; checker that classifies "same sequence" or "different sequence" and flags any arm using more than one stream; fills the arms table's synchronisation column; classifies each synchronisation by mechanism and splits composites (an `assert` on a GPU tensor, sizing from `nonzero()`) into a kernel plus a synchronisation | Code | | Tested on recorded traces of two code paths | Partly built (25 Oct 2026): `op_sequence.py` and `trace_recording.py` in `attnbench/components/`. A PyTorch profiler trace is parsed into the operation sequence; each wait is classified by mechanism, composites are split, and more than one stream is flagged; sequences are compared, the synchronisation map is built, and a sequence is converted for the recursion. A blocking copy from the host and an event synchronise are priced (25 Oct 2026); an implicit wait in `cudaFree` is flagged in the record and the arms table and is not costed (Appendix A, 25 and 31 Oct 2026). The strict "same sequence" is built (31 Oct 2026). Tested on synthetic traces and on a real CPU profiler trace. Still to come: the recorded GPU traces of two code paths (T2.27, step 2), the looser (secondary) "same sequence" definition, which is not yet defined (an open item in T4.1), and the arms table's synchronisation column, filled from those traces |
| T2.4 | In-order device replay of each arm's kernel sequence as a CUDA graph with recorded masks (primary); isolated per-operation replay (cross-check); cache-effect report | Code | T2.3 | Replay vs trace check passes end to end in the L4 shakedown (T2.27, step 3); the P1 read is Gate A's (Section 7) | Partly built (27 Oct 2026): `mask_bank.py`, `sync_tape.py`, `recorder.py` and `replay.py` in `attnbench/components/`. The estimator's masks are banked at every kernel call and substituted at replay; every host-device interaction of an eager prefill is taped and served during capture, so the graph holds no wait; the graph replay, the isolated cross-check with an L2 flush, the cache effect and the replay-versus-trace family check at a bound passed in are built. Tested on CPU with stand-ins; not run on a GPU. The bank's manifest is checked on load: each call's density is recomputed from its mask, and a hash covers the density and causal fields (Appendix A, 31 Oct 2026). Still to come: pricing substituted positions from an isolated replay of the original operator, with the cost source flagged per position (`device_costs` refuses an incomplete match until then), the bound from the shakedown, and the GPU runs (T2.27, step 3) |

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| T2.5 | Link microbenchmarks: pinned and pageable bandwidth, s_fixed per synchronisation mechanism at the smallest payload with the device idle, PCIe, loaded bandwidth, NUMA node | Code | | All fields in one provenance-stamped row | Partly built (25 Oct 2026): `link.py` in `attnbench/components/`, run by `measure_link.py`, tested on CPU with a virtual device and a dry run. One row holds s_fixed for each of the recursion's five mechanisms at one byte with the device idle; pinned and pageable bandwidth both ways from CUDA events; blocking device-to-host bandwidth for the two copy mechanisms; the same six under a CPU load in a separate process at each grid length; PCIe generation and width, read while a copy runs; and the GPU's NUMA node against the process's affinity. `mechanism_costs` and `hardware_features` turn it into the recursion's and the learned baseline's inputs. The row itself is made on the L4 (T2.27). Bandwidth is measured in both directions (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). Still to build: s_fixed for a blocking host-to-device copy and for an event synchronise (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). Proposed, awaiting the researcher: the load is the reference mask builder at density 0.5, and the learned baseline's bandwidths are host to device |
| T2.6 | Launch-queue depth probe | Code | | Q measured on the L4 | Partly built (25 Oct 2026): `launch_queue.py` in `attnbench/components/`, run by `scripts/measure_launch_queue.py`. A long spin kernel, then short kernels launched behind it and timed on the host; the first launch that waits for the spin marks a full queue, so Q is the number of operations in flight, the spin included, which is the Q of the recursion's D_(i-Q). Each trial that never fills the queue gives only a lower bound, and `queue_depth` refuses trials that disagree. Tested on CPU against a simulated queue that the recursion's queue term reproduces; Q is measured on the L4 (T2.27). Two kernels are probed, the null kernel and a one-element add, because a launch's queue footprint can depend on its arguments; the model's Q is the null kernel's (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026) |
| T2.7 | Trace checks: copy-kernel concurrency, unified-memory faults | Code | | Flags tested on synthetic traces | Done (25 Oct 2026): `trace_checks.py` in `attnbench/analysis/`, run by `check_trace.py`, flags tested on synthetic Kineto traces and synthetic Nsight Systems exports. The Kineto check flags a copy that overlaps a kernel or memset on another stream (an overlap on the same stream is a timestamp artifact, counted apart) and any managed-memory copy or call. Claim scope (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026): a run checked only from its Kineto trace may claim no managed-memory use, not no page faults. Only the separate nsys-traced pass of the L4 shakedown may claim no page faults, and only for the arms it traced, and only when `scripts/um_fault_control.py`, run under the same nsys options in that session, recorded faults. The nsys pass is never a timing run. Whether nsys is on the v7 image is not on record; the shakedown checks it with `check_trace.py nsys-available` |

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| T2.8 | The recursion, with hand-computed unit tests | Code | | Tests pass | Done (22 Oct 2026): `attnbench/predict/recursion.py`, tested by hand-computed timelines and an independent pending-launch checker (`tests/test_predict_recursion.py`); a synchronisation carries no host cost and a prefill ends with the closing synchronise (Appendix A, 22 Oct 2026) |
| T2.9 | Sum, fitted sum (trained only on pairings already run when each prediction is committed; full leave-one-pairing-out as a labelled retrospective secondary) and KernelSight-style baselines; HDBI diagnostic; model ablations (no synchronisation term, host-only and device-only bounds) | Code | T2.8 | Tests pass | Done (25 Oct 2026): in `attnbench/predict/` (`baselines.py`, `hdbi.py`, `training.py`, `ablations.py`), tests pass: the sum as written and a sum + s_0; the fitted sum as written and a fitted sum + s_0, each minimising absolute relative error with committed and retrospective training sets and a condition-number report; the KernelSight-style step form; HDBI, with a boundedness classification whose thresholds the caller states (TaxBreak gives none); both synchronisation ablations; host-only and device-only bounds (Appendix A, 22 and 25 Oct 2026) |
| T2.10 | Learned LightGBM baseline, trained only on pairings already run when each prediction is committed; full leave-one-pairing-out as a labelled retrospective secondary; learning curve over 1 to 6 training pairings | Code | T2.8 | Features frozen in code | Done (25 Oct 2026): `attnbench/predict/learned.py` and `intensity.py`, tests pass; features frozen in code, with the six kernel classes for arithmetic intensity (QKV projection, attention, output projection, MLP, norm, LM head) and the definition of transfer demand confirmed (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026), so estimator scoring has no class; LightGBM 4.6.0 as the optional `learned` extra, run on one thread |

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| T2.11 | Prediction commit for the recursion, the fitted sum and the learned predictor together: hash, sync, analysis refuses late predictions (K9); each baseline's record names the pairings it was trained on | Code | T2.8 | Refusal tested | Built (25 Oct 2026): `commit.py` in `attnbench/predict/`. One hashed file per pairing holds, per cell, the recursion, the Sum, the Sum + s_0 and the step form, computed from the cell's priced components, and the committed fitted sum and learned predictor, each naming the pairings it was trained on; optionally the constant-host-cost and nearest-pairing baselines and intervals. The file is synced and read back. The analysis refuses a file synced at or after the timed workload started, one whose bytes or predictions do not follow from its own contents, and one whose baselines were trained on a pairing banked after it; each refusal is tested. Scoring (H1, residuals, the T3.x tables) refuses any prediction not read through `load_committed`, which checks the sync time (Appendix A, 31 Oct 2026). A learned prediction needs the locked configuration. Widened (27 Oct 2026): the file is schema `/2`, and each cell is keyed by model, code path, arm, density, context length and batch (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026), as the named tuple `training.CellKey`. The file carries each code path's definition (GPU, implementation, library versions, `sys.flags.optimize`), and a code path's label is checked against its definition on write and on read; a cell naming an undefined label, a definition no cell uses, a duplicate full key and a `/1` file are all refused, each with a break-test. Accepted by the researcher (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026): the label is the GPU, the implementation, the optimise flag and a hash of the whole definition, without the arm; the nearest-pairing baseline matches model, arm, density, length and batch but not the code path, since a code path names a GPU and an exact match would never cross GPUs (two source code paths for one cell are refused, and `source_code_path` names the one to read); the queue sensitivity pairs a sparse cell with the dense cell of its model, length and batch, not its code path, since the dense and sparse implementations differ by construction (two dense cells there are refused). T2.13's ground-truth rows carry no cell identity yet; the join to this key is the session runner's |

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| T2.12 | Precomputed-mask ablation arm | Code | | Passes selector gate | Partly built (27 Oct 2026); it has run only on a CPU, with a stand-in for the kernel: `attnbench/precomputed_masks.py`. `MaskRecorder` runs a source arm once, untimed, and records the block mask each layer handed the kernel (the model wrapper's mask, the per-head selector's, or the estimator's own return for XAttention, sliced as the arm slices it). `MaskSet` carries them with the digest of the prompt that produced them, since a mask is valid only for that prompt, and saves with a sha256 sidecar. `PrecomputedMaskBackend` makes them device-resident and contiguous at construction and, in its forward, repeats the KV heads and calls `kernels.bsa_prefill`, the one kernel call site, so the executed density is recorded as for any arm. It computes no score, builds no mask and reads nothing from the host. Batch 1 only (the kernel call's limit, as XAttention's), so the batch-4 cells have no precomputed-mask arm (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026). In the ground-truth harness it is a new arm kind that is labelled an ablation, is refused any scoring call or mask build in any phase, and is refused a prompt other than its own. Tested: the kernel receives the recorded masks unchanged and without a per-forward copy; a replay reproduces its source arm's output; the stored per-head masks equal the head-uniform mask bitwise when heads share scores (the selector gate, Section 5.5); a set cannot be replayed on another prompt. Every check has been watched to fail under a mutation (27 Oct 2026). Still to do: the same on a GPU with the real kernel (L4 dry run; Shakedown 2's `t212` is built, 28 Oct 2026, and not run: it records mean-pool's and XAttention's masks, replays them through the real kernel, compares logits and executed density, and times the source and precomputed arms together), where the replay is expected to match its source arm bitwise for XAttention; it is not yet known to for mean-pool, whose banked path leaves the kernel's `deterministic` flag at its default. The arm is not registered with the backend registry, since it is bound to one prompt's masks |

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| T2.13 | Untraced ground-truth harness: arms interleaved, except compiled variants, which run one per process (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026); dense control, traced-vs-untraced overhead, median, p90 and p99, GPU clock and throttle sampling; records the timestamp of the first timed block, which the late-prediction check reads (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). Every deployable arm's timed region includes its estimator, mask build, copies and synchronisations; the oracle arm may use cached scores and is labelled a non-deployable reference (scoring cost outside the timed path) (Appendix A, 26 Oct 2026; label corrected 27 Oct 2026) (adapt `run_vectorised_endtoend.py` / `phase_timing.py`, both of which compute scores before the clock starts) | Code | | L4 dry run; an acceptance test fails if a deployable arm's scores are computed outside the timed block | Partly built (27 Oct 2026; follow-ups 28 Oct 2026); it has run only against fakes on a CPU (its dry-run step also runs on a CPU, on the dense arm with a scripted reader): `attnbench/ground_truth.py` and `attnbench/clock_sampling.py`. Arms are timed interleaved, in an order that rotates each round, with the device synchronised on both sides of each timed block; the median, p90 and p99 and the start of the first ground-truth block are recorded (a rerun never moves it; tested against `load_committed`'s late-prediction refusal, which refuses a prediction synced at or after the stamp). Under the strict rule (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026) the stamp is the start of the first clocked block of any kind, the dense control's clocked warm-up included, so a prediction synced during that warm-up is late; built 28 Oct 2026, and the result key is now `first_clocked_block_started_at` (`check_control` of T2.16 reads the same stamp). A probe logs every scoring call and mask build; a deployable arm is refused if any ran before the clock started or if a timed block computed no scores, and the oracle's rows carry the label. Exactly one dense control is required. Its warm-up time is the median of its clocked warm-up forwards after the cold first one, and a round whose dense time differs from that by more than the resolution floor, in either direction, is flagged. GPU clocks and throttle reasons are read around every timed block, outside the clock, from NVML's cumulative power and thermal violation counters, because an instantaneous read after the closing synchronise sees only an idle GPU; a reader without those counters needs an in-block sampling thread and is refused without one. Which reasons flag a block is set per session and has no default in the code; the researcher's set (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026) is hardware slowdown, the two thermal slowdowns and the hardware power brake, and the software power cap, normal on an L4 under load, is recorded and never flags. A flagged round is excluded from every statistic and rerun within a stated budget, and a result with too few clean rounds says `complete: false`. `time_with_profiler_overhead` measures the untraced ground truth first and the traced run second, in that order, and reports the per-arm overhead against the resolution floor. An arm names its compile setting, the harness checks it against the backend, and a second compiled setting in one process is refused. Every check has been watched to fail under a mutation (27 Oct 2026). The session's detector is a separate sampler process reading the throttle-reason bits at about 10 Hz (`ProcessSampler`, built 28 Oct 2026, tested on a scripted card), because hardware slowdown has no counter and the power counter holds the software cap and the hardware brake together. The rule is on the bits alone: `RESEARCHER_FLAG_BITS` (hardware slowdown, both thermal slowdowns, the |

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| | | | | | hardware power brake) flags and the software power cap is recorded and never flags. Each block is judged on the samples inside it and the one either side, so a block shorter than the interval is still bracketed; a dead, stalled or unbuildable sampler stops the session. The in-process sampler's counters flag only if every bit a counter integrates is in the set, which closes the open point about the power counter. The session's controls refuse a counters-only sampler and any flag set missing one of the four bits above (31 Oct 2026). Still owed: running it. Shakedown 2 (`scripts/t228_steps.py`, launch card `docs/t228_launch_card.md`) has the steps, built 28 Oct 2026 and not run: `nvml` (the real NVML reader and the sampler process against a card) and `t213` (the harness on the shakedown arms, the stamp, the sampler's own cost on a host-bound arm, the traced overhead, `check_control`). The resolution floor is the researcher's at lock, and the dry run uses a provisional one |
| T2.14 | One container image for GCP and AWS | Code | | Boots on both | Not started |
| T2.15 | Queue-sensitivity and residual analysis code | Code | T2.8 | Tested | Built (25 Oct 2026): `sensitivity.py` and `residuals.py` in `attnbench/predict/`. The queue sensitivity re-runs a committed file's own components at each multiple of Q and with no queue term, and names the depths at which the sparse-versus-dense decision would flip. Residuals carry the arm, the synchronisation count and the arm class; one inside the noise floor is marked, never dropped |

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| T2.16 | Dense-baseline selection (K2): candidate kernels, correctness and fault check, warm-up timing, recorded choice; restate banked A100 figures from measurements | Code | | Tested on CPU fakes; L4 dry run | Partly built (27 Oct 2026): `attnbench/dense_selection.py`, tested on CPU fakes with the real correctness gate. One call per cell (card, context length, batch): each planned candidate (SDPA flash, cuDNN, memory-efficient, FA2, and FA3 on the H100) is declined where its own capability says it faults the device, and is then never launched; checked with `gates.check_for_family`, which uses the float64 reference where it fits and agreement among the other candidates where it does not, and the check kind is named per candidate; and timed in interleaved warm-up rounds. The choice is the lowest median among candidates that were correct and ran every round, with every candidate within the resolution floor of it listed. A planned candidate that was not supplied makes the record `complete: false`, and `check_control` refuses it. The record is written once with a sha256 sidecar, and loading recomputes every median from its samples and the choice from the medians. `check_control` requires the dense control to be the recorded choice, the record complete, and the record made before the first timed block. `check_control` takes the prediction key (or its K2 cell) and refuses a choice recorded for another card, context length or batch (Appendix A, 31 Oct 2026). `measured_restatement` states a speedup only from one session in which the dense arm is the chosen kernel; `arithmetic_restatement` reproduces the banked A100 caveat's 1.072x, 1.180x and 1.260x at 16384 from the parquets and labels them arithmetic. Still to do: a backend for FA3 (none exists, so the H100 record is incomplete), a prerequisite of T6.4 (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026); the tolerance, which is the gate's T0L and is not yet fixed at lock; the L4 dry run, for which Shakedown 2's `t216` (K2 at one cell, record written and read back) and `t213` (which calls `check_control` against that record) are built (28 Oct 2026) and not run; building `t216` found that a record named for "NVIDIA L4" could not be read back, since the space broke the sha256 sidecar, and the file name is now sanitised; and the same-session A100 measurement that replaces the arithmetic restatements. Every check has been watched to fail under a mutation (27 Oct 2026) |

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| T2.17 | XAttention arm with Python asserts removed: module-scoped import hook compiling only the authors' `xattn` package with `optimize=1`, never reading or writing the bytecode cache; per-session check that the default arm still carries its asserts, that the stripped code differs only in assert sequences and __debug__ blocks, and that the hook's log of compiled modules matches the `xattn` package with `sys.flags.optimize` at 0; confirm no harness safety check relies on `assert` (none in `attnbench/`; three scripts use it); bitwise mask and output gate against the shipped arm | Code | | Hook, cache rule and both checks tested on CPU; gate passes on the L4 | Partly built (27 Oct 2026): `assert_strip.py` in `attnbench/` and backend `xattention_noassert` with `AssertGate`. The hook, the cache rule and the session checks are tested on CPU, and the session check passed on the real upstream package at e379887 on a CPU. Still to come: the bitwise mask and output gate on the L4 |
| T2.18 | Structural probe: each arm at 2048 and 4096 tokens under the profiler (a chunked arm at three probe lengths, each with at least two chunks), order kept and durations discarded, extended by the chunking rule; where the result is "different", the full-length structure recorded with durations discarded (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026) | Code | T2.3 | Tested on the L4 against a full trace | Partly built (27 Oct 2026): `structural_probe.py` in `attnbench/components/` records at 2048 and 4096 through the T2.4 recorder, keeps sequences and masks, extends by the chunking rule or returns "different" with the reason, and compares with a full trace. Tested on CPU on synthetic programs. Still to come: three probe lengths with at least two chunks each for chunked arms (XAttention at its official chunk size has one chunk at 2048, 4096 and 16384, and four at 32768), the full-length structure recording, and the L4 test |
| T2.19 | Constant-host-cost and nearest-measured-pairing baselines; decision error, crossover error and bootstrap prediction intervals; crossover bracket rule (primary) and quadratic fit with residual (secondary) | Code | T2.8 | Tests pass | Built (25 Oct 2026): `naive.py`, `intervals.py`, `crossover.py` and `scoring.py` in `attnbench/predict/`. The constant-host-cost baseline; the nearest measured pairing, with a tie refused; bootstrap intervals over the component measurements' repeats, with a fixed resampling protocol; the bracket rule and the quadratic fit with its residual; crossover error (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026); decision error and sign agreement, a predicted tie counting as dense in both, and cells inside the resolution floor listed apart by `score_cells` (Appendix A, 26 Oct 2026) |

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| T2.20 | Provenance on every row: CPU microcode version and instance generation; provisioning model (on-demand, spot, DWS flex-start or reserved); `sys.flags.optimize`; mask density and executed density | Code | | Fields present and tested | Done (25 Oct 2026): every provenance stamp carries `cpu_microcode`, `instance_type`, `instance_generation` (the machine series), `provisioning_model` with `provisioning_model_problem`, and `python_optimize` (`sys.flags.optimize`). The provisioning model is the tag each launch script's create call writes, checked against GCP's `scheduling/preemptible`. Mask density and executed density are on every ground-truth row, checked by `gt_schema` (31 Oct 2026). On AWS the tag, instance type and family are read over IMDSv2 and checked against `instance-life-cycle` (31 Oct 2026; tested against a fake only). `attnbench/densities.py` gives mask density and executed density, the second recorded from the tensor handed to the kernel; the ground-truth harness (T2.13) puts both on its rows (Appendix A, 25 Oct 2026). AWS rows get these fields with T5.1 |
| T2.21 | Compiled variants: wrap each arm in `torch.compile` (default settings, and with the capture options); graph-break report per layer on CPU; mask agreement with the eager arm; compile time and recompile counts kept outside timed blocks; one setting per process; no mean-pool compiled variant (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026) | Code | T2.3 | Graph-break report on CPU; L4 dry run | Partly built (27 Oct 2026): `compiled.py` in `attnbench/backends/`. Variants under the default settings and the capture options, one setting per process (Dynamo does not guard compiled code on its own settings), compile events kept outside timed blocks, eager fallback refused, a graph-break report per layer and mask agreement with the eager arm; tested on CPU on dense SDPA and the XAttention backend over a stand-in package. Still to come: the report on the real XAttention package (needs CUDA) and the L4 dry run. Vertical-slash is not built (T1.7). The patterns in Section 1 were checked on CPU on 6 Oct 2026 and banked 19 Oct 2026 in `results/compile_graph_breaks_cpu/` for PyTorch 2.8.0 and 2.14.1 |

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| T2.22 | Dispatcher and its comparators (kernel-speedup rule, always dense, best-kernel sparse arm, nearest pairing); regret and decision errors, with and without the Holm-corrected admissible set; margin-against-speedup frontier; choice written into the hashed prediction file | Code | T2.8, T2.11, T2.19 | Tests pass on synthetic grids | Done (27 Oct 2026): `dispatcher.py` in `attnbench/predict/`, tested on a hand-worked grid, with a mutant for each rule and guard. The dispatcher takes the admissible configuration with the shortest predicted time and dense unless it is faster by more than the resolution floor (Section 5.9; exactly the floor is dense). The comparators are the kernel-speedup rule, always dense, one fixed best-kernel configuration and the nearest pairing's best measured choice. Scoring is on the measured grid at 16384 and 32768: regret (mean and worst), decision errors by the `scoring.py` outcomes with cells inside the floor not interpreted, and time gained against always-dense; `dense_best_everywhere` marks the case where always-dense has zero regret. Every admissible set is evaluated by label, so the uncorrected and the Holm-corrected sets sit side by side, and dropping an arm from a set removes it from the choices and from the reference (the per-arm gate rule, Section 5.1). `margin_frontier` sweeps the accuracy margin (admissible iff the lower bound is above minus the margin, the rule `paired_exact_ni` applies, checked against it) and reports the speedup each margin buys. The choices of the dispatcher and of each comparator are written into the hashed prediction file with their inputs, and the analysis recomputes every one from the file's own predictions and refuses a file whose choices do not follow (K9). Accepted by the researcher (Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026): ties among equal predicted times, or equal kernel speedups, go to the smaller (arm, density); "always the sparse arm with the best kernel speedup" is read as one fixed configuration, the one with the best geometric-mean kernel speedup over the points where it is admissible, left unscored where a point lacks it. Proposed, awaiting the researcher: the dispatcher decides per model, context length and batch; an arm on two code paths at one point is refused unless the deployed code path is named. Owed from elsewhere: the Holm-corrected set, which the admissibility analysis produces once its family is declared at lock (T4.1), and the real kernel times, which are device components from the T2.4 replays |
| T2.23 | Mask gate on P2: run XAttention's Triton and PyTorch paths on the same recorded prompts through `use_triton`; per-layer mask agreement and density difference against P1's masks | Code | T2.3 | Tested on CPU fixtures; run in the P2 session | Not started |
| T2.24 | Mask comparison of P4's recorded Triton masks against P2's; decides whether P6 inherits P4's masks | Code | T2.23 | Comparison code tested; run after P4 | Not started |

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T2.25 | Delay-injection slope check for Gate A: inject each synchronisation mechanism separately into the dense arm, where the GPU is busy and where it is idle; one predicted-over-measured slope per mechanism | Code | T2.8 | Tested on CPU; L4 run in T3.1 | Built (31 Oct 2026): `delay_injection.py` in `attnbench/predict/` plans the busy and idle variants, predicts each with the recursion, and scores a ratio per placement and one pooled slope per mechanism against a bound set at lock. `plan_variants` takes the sites the injector accepts (`sites_allowed`, from `delay_injector.injectable_sites`), so a plan never names a site inside a multi-operation call. `attnbench/components/delay_injector.py` is the injector (after a launching call, at the dispatcher; it refuses a site inside a call), with `observed`, which wraps the prefill for T2.2's null pass so the predicted host costs carry the observer's overhead, and `observer_effect`, which reports the observer's own effect. Tested on CPU; the L4 run is in T3.1 |
| T2.26 | GPU variants of the five GQA tests named in `tests/_sdpa_env.py`, with the device taken from the environment, called from the session preflight; wire `scripts/gpu_suite_record.sh` into the launch scripts. The five tests pin `device="cpu"`, so as written they check nothing on a GPU instance | Code | | Variants tested on CPU; each launch script runs the suite record before measuring; variants pass on the L4 in the T3.1 preflight | Partly built (28 Oct 2026): GPU variants of the five tests (`tests/test_*_gpu.py`, `tests/_gpu_env.py`: device from `ATTNBENCH_TEST_DEVICE`, dtype from `ATTNBENCH_TEST_DTYPE`, default bfloat16, skipped without CUDA). They have not run on a GPU, are not yet called from the session preflight, and `scripts/gpu_suite_record.sh` is not yet wired into the launch scripts |
| T2.27 | L4 shakedown: one planned session that runs the L4 steps of T2.2 to T2.7, T2.13, T2.16, T2.17 and T2.21 from the checklist below; GCP, launch by 9 Dec 2026 | Code + R | The code of T2.2 to T2.7, T2.13, T2.16, T2.17 and T2.21 | Each step passes, or its failure and fix are recorded; rows banked | Not started |

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T2.28 | Density sensitivity: every committed prediction recomputed at plus and minus the measured cross-path density difference (Section 5.4) | Code | T2.4 | Tested | Built (27 Oct 2026): `density_sensitivity.py` in `attnbench/predict/`, tested on hand-computed families and with a mutant for each guard. It reads a committed file alone: an arm is committed at several densities, each with the device costs T2.4 replayed from its own recorded masks, so each position's host, link, device and synchronisation cost is interpolated linearly in density between the two nearest committed densities (extrapolated from the nearest two outside the range, and flagged), and the recursion and every other predictor that reads only the components are re-run at the committed Q. The learned predictor and the nearest-pairing baseline cannot be recomputed from the file and are listed, as is a family with one density, with different operation sequences, with a repeated density, a density outside (0, 1], an interpolated component below zero, and an arm with no measured difference; nothing is assumed zero. `nonlinearity` reports how far the middle densities sit from the chord, since linear is an assumption. `decision_flips` names the offsets at which the predicted sign of sparse minus dense changes (a tie is dense). Proposed, awaiting the researcher: the difference is an absolute change in mask density by arm or by arm and length, supplied by the mask gate (T2.23, not built), and the abscissa is the key's density unless the measured mask density of each cell is given. Still to come: the gate's output feeding `deltas`, and the real replays at several densities (T2.27, T3.1) |

**T2.27 checklist: the L4 shakedown session.** One session on the L4 in `asia-northeast1-a`. Each step is recorded as passed, or as failed with its fix, and every row is banked with `git_dirty = False`. Each task's own "Done when" still decides that task.

1. T2.2: smoke run of the null-kernel host-component profiler; profile the reference mask builder on the L4's host and bank the profile.
2. T2.3: record traces of two code paths, with the GPU stream IDs used, for the sequence checker's tests.
3. T2.4: replay each arm's kernel sequence as a CUDA graph with recorded masks, and run the replay-versus-trace check end to end. This is a dry run; the check of record is P1's, in T3.1.
4. T2.5: the link microbenchmarks, every field in one provenance-stamped row.
5. T2.6: measure the launch-queue depth Q.
6. T2.13: dry run of the untraced ground-truth harness.
7. T2.16: dry run of the dense-baseline selection.
8. T2.17: the asserts-removed XAttention arm's per-session checks, and its bitwise mask and output gate against the shipped arm.
9. T2.21: dry run of the compiled variants.
10. T2.7: check whether nsys is on the image (`check_trace.py nsys-available`). If it is not, install it in this session and record that here. Then, in a separate traced pass that is never a timing run, run `um_fault_control.py` and the arms under the same nsys options, and run `check_trace.py nsys-faults` on each export. "No page faults" holds only for the arms that pass traced, and only if the control faulted.

## Phase 3: P1 gate

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T3.1 | P1 session: components, committed prediction, ground truth; GCP, launch by 9 Dec 2026 | Code prepares; R runs | Every Phase 2 task Built or Done, except T2.14's AWS half, T2.22 and T2.23 to T2.26; T2.27 Done | Rows banked | Partly built (31 Oct 2026): the session runner `scripts/t31_session.py`, its steps `scripts/t31_steps.py`, the config `configs/t31/p1_session.json` and the launch card `docs/t31_launch_card.md` (cap ₹760: a 7 h halt at ₹108.64/h). It runs the eleven steps in order, stops at the first failure, logs each step and resumes from a named step. Prediction steps write, sync and read back the file; `hold` waits until the instance clock reads the sync time plus `PLANNED_SYNC_WAIT_S` (90 s, from `predict/commit.py`; a real session's config may not set its own, and a test scans the runner for literals); each ground-truth process checks the same release itself and stamps `clock_not_before` before its first forward; `verify` runs the analysis's own `load_committed` against the store (P1 is the first pairing, so `banked_at` is empty). The throttle detector is the sampler process (`ProcessSampler`). Tested on a CPU dry run with fake components and a local store. Not built: the `probe`, `host_components`, `device_components` and `ground_truth` steps refuse on a GPU with the task each waits for; the config's undecided values (densities, groups, repeats, floors, rerun budget, sampler interval) are T4.1's and a real run refuses any of them null. Not run on a GPU |
| T3.2 | P1 repeat sessions for between-session floors; set probe bounds; report the cloud noise floor as a number; GCP, launch by 9 Dec 2026 | Code + R | T3.1 | Bounds proposed for lock | Not started |
| T3.3 | Gate A decision | Chat + R | T3.1 | Recorded in Appendix A | Not started |

## Phase 4: Pre-registration lock

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T4.1 | Fix every **[lock]** value: H0 to H3 tolerances, H6 regret bound, the ground-truth density set, H4 equivalence bound with its justification from the tasks, H4 confirmatory family, power target and n, primary cell n (at least 200) and admissibility n, admissibility Holm family, the context grid checked against each model's position limit, delay-injection slope bound, mask-gate bound, cross-card dense task-score bound, replay-versus-trace bound for Gate A (set from the L4 shakedown's agreement distribution, Appendix A, 27 Oct 2026), null-kernel floor multiple, probe bounds, resolution and noise floors (from the measured run-to-run spread), floors quantile (0.95 is provisional, for shakedowns only), the HDBI boundedness threshold (fitted on the training pairings), learned-predictor features, learned-predictor hyperparameters, K2 correctness tolerance (the gate's T0L), head-type criterion (T1.3), rerun budget (flagged rounds, and the minimum clean rounds), throttle set, payload class edges (proposed 8 B, 4 KiB and 1 MiB), prompt-set hash and tokenizer version, realised-length key rule, budget cut order | Chat + R | T3.2, T1.5, T1.3 | Values written here | Not started. Open: the looser (secondary) "same sequence" definition is undefined and needs a decision before the list is complete |
| T4.2 | Confirm the accuracy test and the dense floor (K7) | Chat + R | | Written here | Decision |

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T4.3 | Two independent adversarial reads of plan and scoring code | R arranges | T4.1, T2.22 | Findings resolved | Not started |
| T4.4 | Tagged lock commit | Code | T4.3 | Tag on origin | Not started |

## Phase 5: AWS tooling

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Done when | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T5.1 | AWS launch, cleanup, cost cap, hard-delete limit, teardown with the GCP guarantees; tests against a fake CLI | Code | | Tests pass | Partly built (28 Oct 2026): `scripts/aws_launch_session.sh`, `aws_cleanup_check.sh`, `aws_teardown_session.sh`, `_aws_account.sh` and `_aws_launch_policy.sh`, tested against a fake `aws` CLI. The account and profile are pinned outside the repository; a launch needs a planning rate, a cost cap and a hard-delete limit and is refused when rate times limit exceeds the cap; the instance halts in-guest, an EventBridge schedule terminates it at the limit, on-demand only, IMDSv2 only; teardown saves the console log, results, age manifest and `session_cost.txt` before terminating. Not run against AWS. Open: regions, AMI, key pair, security group, the confirmed rates and launch date, and the quotas (T5.2) |
| T5.2 | Service quotas for G6, G6e, p5.4xlarge, G5; regional availability | R | | Quotas granted | Not started |
| T5.3 | Cost every pairing session | Code | T5.1 | Table in `docs/spend_ledger.md` | Not started |

## Phase 6: Pairings (each with its prediction committed first; rows in run order)

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| T6.1 | P2 (Cascade Lake + A100): H0, H1, H2; GCP, launch by 9 Dec 2026 | Code prepares; R runs | Gate B | Not started |
| T6.4 | P4 (Sapphire Rapids + H100): H1, H3; GCP, launch by 9 Dec 2026 | Code; R | Gate B; an FA3 backend (T2.16) | Partly built (27 Oct 2026): the H100 launch path submits the flex-start request with `--async`, polls it in bounded calls, cancels it at a client deadline (6900 s, inside the 2 h server window) with the cancel confirmed before any other zone, and checks the date before each submit (`scripts/gcp_launch_h100.sh`, `scripts/_flex_request.sh`, `tests/test_flex_request.py`); not run on GCP, so the status words it relies on are Google's documentation, not yet observed here. The FA3 backend and wheel build are built (28 Oct 2026, `docs/t64_fa3_plan.md` Section 8): `attnbench/backends/fa3.py`, tested on CPU with a stand-in; the build script, H100 import check and build-VM launcher, tested against a fake `gcloud`. Researcher's decisions: the latest release (v2.8.3.post2, commit 49774b31), `n2-standard-16` on-demand in `us-central1`, no third-party wheel. The first build (28 Oct 2026, Rs 176) was killed for memory and left no wheel; the second is the restricted build (head dim 128, forward, bf16 and fp16; `docs/t64_fa3_plan.md` Section 9), with a self-halting build VM and a watcher, and has a launch card (`docs/t64_fa3_launch_card.md`, cap Rs 232); not launched. No H100 session is approved or priced |

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| T6.2 | P3 (AMD + L4): H0, H1, H2 | Code; R | Gates B, C | Not started |
| T6.3 | P5 (AMD + L40S): H0, H1, H2, H5; chunked extension | Code; R | Gates B, C | Not started |
| T6.5 | P6 (AMD + H100): H0, H1, full transfer, H5 | Code; R | T6.2 to T6.4 | Not started |
| T6.6 | P7 (AMD 2nd gen + A10G), optional | Code; R | Budget | Not started |

### Phase 7: Analysis and writing

| ID | Task | Owner | Depends | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| T7.1 | H0 to H5 analyses per pairing; residuals by arm and synchronisation count | Code | Phase 6 | Not started |
| T7.2 | Read in full the related work still known only from abstracts (Token Sparse Attention, nn-Meter, HELP, Twilight, FlexPrefill, others in the brief), and papers raised by reviewers (Janus, MOMO; DFSAttn and HiSparse read in full on 5 Oct 2026) | Chat (R supplies PDFs) | | In progress (finished: DFSAttn and HiSparse, read in full 5 Oct 2026; claims verified against full text (machine-checked quotes, `docs/related_work_verified.md`, 28 Oct 2026): MInference, FlexPrefill, SpargeAttn, CompactAttention, the SKIP paper and The Sparse Frontier; to be read in full by the researcher: XAttention, KernelSight-LM, TaxBreak, CTFusion (PDF via IEEE access); remaining: Janus and MOMO, and the brief entries known from abstracts only: nn-Meter, HELP, Vidur, the cross-generation GPU prediction paper (TCAD 2019), The Framework Tax, DuoAttention, Twilight, the CUDA Graphs study (LANMAN 2026), PILOT, iMLBench, Mytkowicz et al. and Token Sparse Attention) |
| T7.3 | IEEE Xplore and Scopus search; related-work section | Chat + R | T7.2 | Not started |
| T7.4 | Venue choice (Section 11) | R with professor | | Not started |
| T7.5 | Paper draft; professor review | R + Chat | T7.1 | Not started |
| T7.6 | Predicted profitability per pairing and estimator: the time model at the admissible density (from recall if H4 holds, otherwise from accuracy runs), against measured profitability | Code | T7.1 | Not started |
| T7.7 | Dispatcher evaluation (H6) on held-out pairings: regret and decision errors against the comparators | Code | T7.6, T2.22 | Not started |

## 9. Known risks

- **Small panel.** Seven pairings; claims are limited to the measured host platforms and GPUs.

- **Limits stated in advance.** Batch 1 and 4 only, with no extrapolation to larger batches. One CUDA stream. G3 is a controlled study scoped to the tested models, tasks and block sizes, not a general law. The chunked-prefill extension is not representative of state-of-the-art chunked prefill.
- **Structural probe may miss length-dependent branches.** Checked by agreement between its two short contexts; a disagreement means the arm's sequence is taken as "different" for H0 and H2.
- **Separability may fail** (Gate D).
- **The whole-process `-O` control is not run** (Appendix A, 12 Oct 2026), so no claim is made about the size of `-O`'s effect on the rest of the process. The isolation of the asserts-removed arm rests on what the instrument does, verified in every session, not on an estimate of what it leaves behind: the hook compiles exactly one package with asserts stripped and logs every module it compiled; the bytecode check confirms that only assert sequences and `__debug__` blocks disappeared from that package; the hook's log matches the `xattn` package and `sys.flags.optimize` is 0, so every other module keeps its asserts; and the default arm is checked to still carry XAttention's asserts.
- **One code-path mismatch with three faces.** XAttention's thresholds were calibrated on the A100's Triton path (T1.1 amendment A4) and are applied on the L4's PyTorch path, where admissibility is measured and from whose masks device costs may be replayed, while the A100 and H100 run the Triton path. The mask gate (Section 7) measures the mismatch, the density sensitivity (Section 5.4) bounds its effect on predictions, and admissibility transfers only if the gate passes.
- **Component profiling may misstate composed behaviour.** Null kernels can understate host cost; in-order graph replay keeps cache state between kernels but not host-induced gaps, and isolated replay (the cross-check) removes cache effects; TaxBreak notes replay is imperfect for synchronisation-heavy kernels, which describes our sparse arms. H1's error on real pairings measures how much this matters.
- **Implementations may remove the synchronisations G2 prices.** Fused, synchronisation-free estimators exist (VSPrefill). On them the model should predict no gain over simpler forms, which is a correct prediction, not a failure; the paired XAttention arms show what the synchronisations cost where they exist. Compilation with capture options may also remove some; the compiled arms measure this, and compiled variants with no wait left are predicted the same way.
- **Profitability may be empty for deployable estimators.** In the pilots none was non-inferior at any tested density. The primary claim is time prediction at a given density.
- **The dispatcher may only tie always-dense.** If no sparse configuration is admissible and faster, its value is in avoiding the kernel-speedup rule's losses, and that is the claim then.
- **A fitted baseline may win.** Each committed prediction of the fitted sum and LightGBM is trained only on the pairings banked before it: one pairing for P2, at most six for the last pairing run. The retrospective leave-one-pairing-out fits train on up to six. Either result is reported, on held-out pairings only.
- **G3 may be partly pre-empted.** Oracle-guided sparse prefill plans to measure recall of oracle support by its learned indexer. H4 is the cross-estimator test; that is how it is positioned if their follow-up appears first.
- **H4 may fail.** That is a result.
- **Cloud hosts are not controllable.** A frequency difference between sessions is the first candidate explanation for any H0 failure.
- **Two providers** add operational risk (Gate C).
- **Sparse speedups are small on the primary model.** The claims concern prediction.

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## 10. Out of scope, and rejected alternatives

**Out of scope:** models needing more than one GPU; decode sparsity; natively trainable sparse attention; continuous batching and batch above 4; chunked prefill beyond Section 5.8; synthetic host speeds as evidence (delay injection only as an instrument check); a new estimator as a headline; timed kernels below block 128; cross-attention; linear attention; contexts above 32768; model families beyond Qwen2.5 and Llama-3.1; a runtime scheduler that reacts to live load.

| Rejected | Reason |
|---|---|
| A head-adaptive or entropy-driven estimator as the contribution | Already explored (FlexPrefill and Twilight, from abstract; AB-Sparse) |

| Rejected | Reason |
|---|---|
| Recall by block size per head as a contribution | AB-Sparse reports it; kept as control K5 |
| Benchmarking estimator cost against quality | Method papers and CompactAttention already report it |
| Oracle masks as a quality ceiling | An attention-mass oracle is a reference, not a task optimum (oracle-guided sparse prefill; The Sparse Frontier) |
| An analytical sparse-kernel model carried across GPU generations | KernelSight-LM finds attention-kernel efficiency transfers poorly across GPU generations ("limited cross-generation transfer", its Section 8); device costs are measured |
| A fitted contention penalty | Would be tuned on the outcomes it predicts |
| A serving simulator as the baseline | Both simulators use per-device profiles and model no host work inside a step; the learned predictor and the KernelSight-style step form are fairer comparators |
| Q sensitivity over {4, 8, 16} | Far below the measured queue scale; sensitivity is relative to measured Q |
| PLA's depth-wise concentration as evidence against H4 | H4 already matches recall per layer; depth is reported as a stratum |
| A bare-metal control pairing (suggested by a reviewer) | Over budget, and the claims concern cloud hosts; the noise floor is reported instead (Section 5.6) |
| A second full-transfer pairing | Needs a new pairing; P7's host and GPU appear nowhere else, so it cannot be one. P6 stays the single full-transfer test, reported as such |
| H4 at one block size only | How recall behaves across block sizes is part of G3; the Holm family handles the extra comparisons |
| A multi-stream arm | Out of scope; the single-stream boundary is stated instead (Section 5.4) |
| Narrowing the study to G3 alone (suggested by a reviewer) | The researcher judges G2 and G3 both genuinely open (5 Oct 2026); both stay in scope |
| Dropping the fitted sum as physically unjustified (suggested by a reviewer) | Having no structure is its purpose: it is the control that shows whether structure helps |
| A runtime scheduler that routes requests by live host load (suggested by a reviewer) | Needs a serving system and a model of live load; the dispatcher decides offline per pairing, context length and batch (Section 5.9) |
| Dropping the constant-host-cost baseline (suggested by a reviewer) | Costs no runs, and tests whether per-operation host costs matter |

## 11. Open questions (for the professor or a reviewer)

1. Does the crossed seven-pairing design answer the validation objection?
2. Is the definition of an unmeasured pairing acceptable, and is P6's full transfer convincing?
3. Are the fitted sum (primary), sum, step form and LightGBM the right comparators; is training each committed prediction only on the pairings already run fair to the learned one, with full leave-one-pairing-out on seven pairings as the retrospective secondary?
4. Is out-of-sample time prediction enough for an IEEE Transactions journal, or is a design contribution also needed (for example a selector driven by the model's predictions)? *Researcher's answer, 6 Oct 2026: a design contribution is added, the profitability dispatcher (Section 5.9). Still open: is it enough for the target venue?*
5. If the model fails out of sample, is a well-characterised negative result publishable at the target venue?
6. Which venue: IEEE TC, TPDS, TCAD or ACM TACO; or ISPASS or MLSys first?

## 12. Repository map

| Path | What it is |
|---|---|
| `docs/RESEARCH_PLAN.md` | This plan (source); `docs/research_plan.pdf` is generated from it |

| Path | What it is |
|---|---|
| `docs/research_brief.pdf` | Short brief for the professor, with the related-work table |
| `docs/code_inventory.md` | Keep / adapt / archive review of the existing code (task T0.4) |
| `docs/development.md` | Developer notes: test-suite counts and skips, and the earlier study's audit documents; its numbers are checked by `tests/test_doc_derived_numbers.py` |
| `docs/spend_ledger.md` | Cloud spend, from teardown-written `session_cost.txt` files |
| `docs/permission_log.md` | Uses of results the researcher has approved (rule 15) |
| `docs/brief/` | Source of the professor brief; `tools/build_brief_pdf.py` renders `docs/research_brief.pdf` |
| `docs/vendor_register.md` | Third-party code copied into the repository, and lines reproduced under permission (rule 8) |
| `scripts/_launch_policy.sh` | Last-launch-date and no-Australia checks used by every GCP launch script |
| `docs/limitations.md`, `docs/claims.md`, `docs/withdrawn_figures.md`, `docs/silent_failure_patterns.md` | Audit history of the banked evidence; annotate, never rewrite |
| `docs/archive/` | Superseded plans and their referee responses |
| `attnbench/` | Harness: provenance, timing, masks, backends, accuracy pipeline, analysis |
| `scripts/` | Session runners and GCP tooling |
| `tools/build_plan_pdf.py` | Renders this file to PDF |

## Appendix A. Decision record (dated, one line each)

- **4 Oct 2026.** Study direction set to predicting when sparse prefill pays across real host-GPU pairings; G2 and G3 lead, G1 is the validation question. Validation only on physically distinct pairings; synthetic host delay is never evidence.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Link cost is its own term; only device costs transfer between hosts.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Cloud CPU frequency is controlled by a measured host-speed probe with bounds fixed from P1 repeat sessions, not by frequency bands.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Baselines: sum, KernelSight-style step form, CTFusion-style LightGBM (leave-one-pairing-out). Serving simulators declined as baselines.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Budget extended by the researcher to cover the AWS pairings (P3, P5, P6, optional P7); each session still capped.
- **4 Oct 2026.** The oracle arm is an attention-mass reference, not a quality ceiling. Recall's primary reference is the arm's own forward pass; the separate dense pass is secondary.
- **4 Oct 2026.** H4 reported by depth third and by head type; recall matched per layer.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Launch-queue sensitivity is relative to measured Q (0.25x to 4x, and none).
- **4 Oct 2026.** SparKV withdrawn by its authors; not cited.
- **4 Oct 2026.** This document replaces the Estimator Frontier plan as the single source of truth.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Code inventory (`docs/code_inventory.md`) confirmed by the researcher as proposed; pre-pivot tag approved.
- **4 Oct 2026.** P1 is a development pairing; H1's confirmatory pairings are P2 to P7.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Fitted-sum baseline (a·sum h + b·sum l + c·sum d, coefficients ≥ 0, leave-one-pairing-out) added beside LightGBM as the fair test of G1.
- **4 Oct 2026.** Run order P1, P2, P4, then P3, P5, P6, P7. Last GCP launch date 22 Nov 2026, enforced in the launch scripts.
- **4 Oct 2026.** H4 sample size set before lock from a power rule; an underpowered result is reported as inconclusive.
- **4 Oct 2026.** GCP machine types and zones pinned for P1, P2 and P4 (Section 5.2).

- **4 Oct 2026.** Researcher approved using the XAttention pilot results in the brief and this plan (`docs/permission_log.md`).
- **4 Oct 2026.** The earlier Claude Doc on this project retired; it now only points here.
- **4 Oct 2026.** A100 kernel ratios restated against PyTorch's SDPA flash kernel; the "estimated A100 baselines" caveat marked unverified (T0.12).
- **5 Oct 2026.** Two referee reviews of the brief and plan triaged; eight changes adopted (the lines below). G2 and G3 both stay in scope; narrowing to G3 alone declined.
- **5 Oct 2026.** Dense baseline chosen by a fixed selection protocol (K2). Banked A100 figures restated against the fastest correct kernel, as estimates, from the caveat found for T0.12.
- **5 Oct 2026.** G2 reframed around host-visible work and synchronisations wherever masks are built; the motivating example no longer rests on the CPU reference builder.
- **5 Oct 2026.** New arm: calibrated XAttention with Python asserts removed (`python -O`), paired with the shipped arm. The arms table records where each arm builds its mask and its synchronisations per layer.
- **5 Oct 2026.** Device time measured by in-order CUDA-graph replay; isolated replay is the cross-check.
- **5 Oct 2026.** Fitted sum is the primary comparison for G1; LightGBM secondary, with a learning curve.
- **5 Oct 2026.** Recall matched only through each estimator's own budget settings; H4 bound justified at lock and a 5-point bound priced. H4 power rule written as a formula (about 1,300 × p at α 0.025 per test and 90% power; the earlier 1,080 assumed α 0.05).
- **5 Oct 2026.** Model ablations (no synchronisation term, host-only, device-only), GPU clock sampling, and p90 and p99 latency added.
- **5 Oct 2026.** G2 separated from TaxBreak in Section 3; TaxBreak's "aggregate residual" remark describes earlier work, not TaxBreak.
- **5 Oct 2026.** DFSAttn and HiSparse read in full; neither pre-empts G2 or G3. Both added to Section 3 and the brief.
- **5 Oct 2026.** A four-reviewer synthesis triaged; proposals A to L adopted (the lines below). Declined: bare-metal control, a second full-transfer pairing, H4 at one block size, a multi-stream arm (Section 10).
- **5 Oct 2026.** (A) G2 narrowed to the order and position within a prefill step of each estimator's data-dependent host work and synchronisations; KernelSight-LM's step formula and per-step scheduler cited from its full text. (L) The question split into RQ1 to RQ3.
- **5 Oct 2026.** (B) "Unmeasured pairing" defined exactly: microbenchmarks and the structural probe only; contention costed from the loaded-bandwidth microbenchmark; no trace or timing of the workload on the target is an input.
- **5 Oct 2026.** (C) Operation sequences recorded per code path, with a structural probe for new code paths; H0 and H2 compare components only within the same sequence.
- **5 Oct 2026.** (D) Gate responses fixed: replay-versus-trace bound in Gate A; null-kernel floor check before H3. (E) Single-stream scope stated.
- **5 Oct 2026.** (F) H4 confirmatory family declared (estimator pairs at three block sizes, Holm); head type and depth thirds exploratory; n sized from the upper 95% bound of the pilot disagreement rate.
- **5 Oct 2026.** (G) Constant-host-cost and nearest-measured-pairing baselines; decision error, crossover error and prediction intervals. (H) Cloud noise floor reported as a number. (I) What is claimed if sparse prefill never pays, stated in advance.
- **5 Oct 2026.** (J) Limits stated: batch 1 and 4, one stream, G3 scoped, chunked extension not representative. (K) Contention load fixed to the largest mask build per context; driver versions matched for H0; dense kernel re-checked in every timed block.
- **5 Oct 2026.** A further single review triaged; four changes adopted. (M) The two halves joined: predicted profitability on an unmeasured pairing combines the time model with the admissible density, from recall if H4 holds (T7.6). (N) Random-selection control at matched recall added to H4 and its Holm family (T1.9). (O) "One stream" explained as in-order GPU work with asynchronous host and GPU, checked from trace stream IDs; G3 stated as a test with prior evidence on both sides. (P) CPU microcode and instance generation recorded on every row (T2.20). Declined: a multi-stream model extension and a serving-simulator baseline.
- **5 Oct 2026.** Last revision from reviewer feedback before the professor's read; no further review-driven changes until then.

- **6 Oct 2026.** The researcher reopened review-driven changes for one further single review (an exception to the line above). Three changes adopted. (Q) Compiled variants of each arm under `torch.compile`, with graph breaks and remaining waits recorded (T2.21); a CPU check found that a tensor `assert`, `.item()` and `nonzero()` break the graph under default settings and a fixed-size `topk` does not. (R) A profitability dispatcher as the design contribution, answering open question 4: an offline choice of dense or sparse per pairing, context length and batch, scored by regret with the kernel-speedup rule as the primary comparator (RQ4, H6, Section 5.9, T2.22, T7.7); ground truth covers every admissible density. (S) Contributions reframed: G2 leads with the cost of data-dependent sparsity (synchronise, pad or fix sizes); TaxBreak's measurement method and the standard recursion are not claimed; scope stated for the abstract. Declined: a bare-metal control (again), a runtime load-aware scheduler, dropping the constant-host-cost baseline.
- **12 Oct 2026.** The researcher reopened changes for the methodology review of 11 Oct (an exception to the 5 Oct line) and decided the following. (1) The checks-removed XAttention arm uses a module-scoped import hook that compiles only the authors' module with asserts stripped, never the whole process; the hook neither reads nor writes the bytecode cache, and every session verifies that the default arm still carries its asserts; the arm is renamed "Python asserts removed", since Triton, `TORCH_CHECK` and other C-level checks stay. (2) Whole-process `python -O` and its dense and mean-pool controls are not run (researcher's decision; the trio was all or nothing). (3) `sys.flags.optimize` recorded on every row (K8).
- **12 Oct 2026.** (4) A synchronisation is costed once: s_0 = s_fixed (measured at the smallest payload) + payload / bandwidth, loaded where the sequence puts the copy alongside host-side work, with l_i and d_i zero for that operation; Section 5.1's c_link split so it no longer conflicts with Section 5.4. (5) Composite mechanisms (an `assert` on a GPU tensor, sizing from `nonzero()`) are split into a kernel plus a synchronisation. (6) Gate A gains a delay-injection slope check, one slope per mechanism (T2.25). (7) The replay-versus-trace check reruns on the first card of every new code path.
- **12 Oct 2026.** (8) Mask gate on P2: both XAttention code paths on one card through `use_triton`, against P1's masks; masks recorded on the target only for the first card of a new code path, and only if the gate fails (T2.23). (9) P4's Triton masks compared with P2's; if they differ, P6 records its own masks and the full-transfer claim is restated (T2.24). (10) Prediction inputs restated uniformly: target microbenchmarks plus the operation sequence and the estimator's selection as functional artifacts per code path, durations discarded; no timing or trace of the composed workload on the target. (11) Mask density and executed density on every row; predictions recomputed at plus and minus the cross-path density difference.
- **12 Oct 2026.** (12) Timed short lengths cost like any other cell. (13) Context grid 2048, 4096, 8192, 16384 and 32768 for every arm (researcher's decision: a balanced grid, since dropping 65536 removes nearly all the extra cost and the short end is where G2's contrast is largest); 2048 and 4096 are model-validation points, not operating points; 65536 dropped (Qwen2.5 stops at 32768; Llama-3.1-8B does not fit there on an L4); cost controlled on the arm-and-density cross; if lengths must be cut, the full grid stays with the synchronising arms and their controls. (14) Crossover reported as a grid bracket widened by bootstrap intervals; H3 predicts a grid interval; the quadratic fit is secondary, with its residual. (15) H6 scored at 16384 and 32768.
- **12 Oct 2026.** (16) The L4 is the accuracy GPU and the A100 the cross-card dense control, accepted on a task-score bound with the exact-match rate reported. (17) K2's correctness reference is float64, following the code, with the cross-backend fallback named per cell. (18) One limitation for the code-path mismatch (thresholds, admissibility and replayed masks from the L4 PyTorch path; Triton on the A100 and H100). (19) Primary accuracy statement is the achieved lower bound; sensitivity at 5 and 10 points; no 2-point column. (20) Margin-against-speedup frontier. (21) Primary cell n = max(200, H4 power rule) (researcher's decision: 200). (22) The union-bound test stays pre-registered; a replacement only if a simulation shows coverage, power secondary. (23) Admissibility is a decision input; its Holm family declared at lock; regret reported with and without the correction.
- **12 Oct 2026.** (24) RQ1, Section 1 and the abstract say the workload has not been timed on the target rather than not run, since the structural probe already runs each arm there at short contexts under the profiler with all durations discarded; Section 5.1 lists what may run on the target. (25) The host-cost method is credited as adapting TaxBreak's null-kernel protocol, which uses null kernels for the launch path, to the whole operation sequence, with host-side compute measured directly at target sizes; the adaptation is not claimed as a contribution. (26) The baseline is named the KernelSight-style step form in the brief as well as the plan; KernelSight-LM's Eq. 4 is named only when describing their paper, so a comparator's performance is never read as a result about their work. (27) Section 9 states what carries the isolation of

the asserts-removed arm without the `-O` control: construction, verified every session (hook log, bytecode check, default-arm check).

- **18 Oct 2026.** New status word *In progress*: started, nothing usable yet, with the finished and remaining pieces named. T7.2 uses it; T0.11 becomes Partly built.
- **18 Oct 2026.** The A100 figures against the fastest correct dense kernel are stated as two kinds of number (Section 2, T0.12): the kernel ratios (0.95x at 8192, 1.84x at 16384) are recomputed from measured per-layer kernel times at the model's head layout, and the end-to-end restatements are arithmetic, not measurements. For the kernel ratios this replaces "as estimates" in the 5 Oct line.
- **18 Oct 2026.** The provisioning model (on-demand, spot, DWS flex-start or reserved) is recorded on every row (Section 5.2, T2.20).
- **18 Oct 2026.** The fitted sum and the learned predictor make committed predictions trained only on the pairings banked before each prediction, hashed with the recursion's (K9, T2.11); in the planned run order P2's are trained on P1 alone, and each prediction file records its training set. H1 scores these. Full leave-one-pairing-out fits are a labelled retrospective secondary. Gate A stays at the sum and the step form, because P1 has no other pairing to train on.
- **18 Oct 2026.** New task T0.17: GCP quota and availability for the P2 and P4 machines in their pinned zones, from the Cloud Quotas API, and whether a DWS flex-start request or the VM start counts as the launch under `scripts/_launch_policy.sh`. Code prepares the commands; the researcher runs them.
- **18 Oct 2026.** Rule 8 amended: third-party code may be copied only as listed in `docs/vendor_register.md`, each entry with its upstream, commit, licence, verbatim or adapted lines, licence and notice, reason, and approval date. Code from a repository with no licence is never vendored; its lines are reproduced only under a permission in `docs/permission_log.md`. Register drafted; approval dates and the `backends/xattention.py` entry are pending.
- **18 Oct 2026.** T0.17 also re-checks the P2 and P4 rates and records the flex-start queue wait, since the launch scripts do not pass `--request-valid-for-duration`.
- **18 Oct 2026.** New task T2.26: GPU variants of the five GQA tests, called from the session preflight, with `scripts/gpu_suite_record.sh` wired into the launch scripts. The five tests pin the CPU, so they check nothing on a GPU instance.
- **19 Oct 2026.** The reference builder's Python-overhead share is restated from about 91% to about 94% of the builder's loop time (Sections 1 and 2; researcher's decision). `docs/limitations.md` gives the profile at 32768 tokens as 0.212 s for the Python loop body and 0.013 s for the torch operations inside it, per 10 calls, so the share is (0.212 − 0.013) / 0.212 = 93.9%; no reading of those figures gives 91%. The profile ran on a laptop CPU, not on the A100 host, and was never banked, so the figure is marked unbanked until it is re-measured on the target host under T2.2. The brief is restated to match; `docs/claims.md`, `docs/limitations.md` and `docs/writeup_input.md` are annotated, not rewritten; the old figure is registered in `docs/withdrawn_figures.md`.
- **19 Oct 2026.** The method (the G2 critical-path model and the profitability dispatcher) is named BUNGA, Block-sparse Utility Navigator for GPU Attention (Section 1). The package and repository keep the name `attnbench`, the measurement harness. `README.md` was rewritten around it (T0.7).
- **19 Oct 2026.** The 6 Oct CPU compile check was reproduced and banked. A plain `assert` on a tensor does not break the graph under default settings; an assert that converts a tensor to a Python bool does. Section 1, the G2 row and T2.21 corrected.
- **19 Oct 2026.** XAttention's assert forms were read from its upstream source (commit `e379887`, `xattn/src/utils.py`; read only, nothing copied). Its prefill path makes two plain asserts on a tensor per query chunk, one inside a `try`/`except`; that form did not split the graph on a CPU. The assert joining two tensor conditions with `and`, which splits, is on the decoding path only. Both forms were added to the banked check (`results/compile_graph_breaks_cpu/`). Whether the compiled code still makes the GPU wait for them is measured under T2.21. Section 1 updated.
- **19 Oct 2026.** The H1 row adds that, if XAttention's plain asserts stay inside the compiled graph on the GPU pairings as they did in the CPU check, the compiled XAttention pair may show only a small gap, and that BUNGA's prediction of that gap, made before it is measured, is a direct test of how it prices a wait that compilation leaves in place (researcher's wording).
- **20 Oct 2026.** T0.17 done from the researcher's Mac with read-only commands: quotas, the outcome of three quota requests (preemptible CPUs raised to 26 in `asia-southeast1` and `us-central1`; GPUs across all

regions kept at 1), zone availability, rates with SKU IDs (Section 5.2), the flex-start wait and when `--max-run-duration` starts counting. Facts only; the launch definition is recorded separately.

- **20 Oct 2026.** Section 5.2's rates table gains a planning rate, all-in: GPU, cores and RAM, plus the 200 GB balanced boot disk and the bundled local SSD. Session cost caps and the spend ledger use it (researcher's decision). Hours per month (730) and local-SSD partition size (375 GiB) are assumptions.
- **21 Oct 2026.** Launch definition adopted (researcher's decision, T0.17): every instance-create request, retries and the Spot fallback included, must be submitted by the end of 22 Nov 2026 IST, and a waiting request counts as launched when submitted. The A100 launcher and the L4 compile session check the date before every attempt; flex-start requests wait at most 15 min (A100) and 2 h (H100) for capacity.
- **21 Oct 2026.** XAttention is credited by authors, paper and code (Xu et al., ICML 2025; arXiv:2503.16428; `mit-han-lab/x-attention` at `e379887`, installed and called, with the lines listed in `docs/vendor_register.md` reproduced) in the README, this plan (RQ2 and the Calibrated XAttention row), `docs/limitations.md` (a dated note), `docs/t4_xattention_calibrated.md` and the brief's reference 18. `docs/permission_log.md` gains a 21 Oct 2026 entry (researcher's decision): all XAttention work, including the pilot results in `docs/claims.md` and `docs/limitations.md`, is approved by the researcher, replacing the 4 Oct 2026 scope; it applies from 21 Oct 2026.
- **21 Oct 2026.** Funding and launch window (researcher's decision): the GCP credit expires on 1 Dec 2026; ₹14,000 of new spend through 30 Nov 2026 23:59 IST; an expense after that is approved by the researcher personally and paid outside the credit; per-session caps unchanged; T3.1, T3.2, T6.1 and T6.4 priced when scheduled (Section 5.2, Funding). The last GCP launch date moves from 22 Nov to 9 Dec 2026, India time, inclusive (rule 14, `scripts/_launch_policy.sh`), and a launch after 30 Nov 2026 says it is outside the credit. Earlier Appendix A lines that name 22 Nov are left as written.
- **21 Oct 2026.** Rule 8 and the vendor register (researcher's decision): every register row states its licence status and a credit line; the five RULER rows are approved; the `xattention.py` row gains its licence status (none upstream) and its authors and paper, with its permission column unchanged. `CLAUDE.md` rule 8 now matches rule 8 here, and a new `CLAUDE.md` rule 11 says any push or merge needs the researcher's explicit yes to that exact action, naming files, branch and destination, recorded in the permission log before acting.
- **21 Oct 2026.** The frontier study's budget gate (`attnbench/analysis/frontier_prereg.py` and its pre-registration, on branch `t11-run-rates-2026-10-20`) moves to the planning rates, with the boot disk inside the rate, and its cap rises from ₹12,000 to ₹14,000 (researcher's decision; the pre-registration is an unlocked draft). Its worst case is ₹10,655, with ₹3,345 to spare. At worst-case inputs H8 is funded whether or not H6a passes (₹277 and ₹2 to spare), and SL, the escalation sessions, the Llama secondary and 65536 runs and the full-set table are cut.
- **21 Oct 2026.** Rule 8's last sentence (researcher's decision): code from a repository with no licence is reproduced only where `docs/vendor_register.md` lists it and the researcher's approval is recorded in `docs/permission_log.md`, replacing "only under a written permission recorded in `docs/permission_log.md`". The register's `xattention.py` row now reads "Researcher's approval recorded in docs/permission_log.md, 21 Oct 2026", pointing to that day's entry.
- **21 Oct 2026.** T0.16 carried out (researcher's decision, option 2). Branch `frontier-prereg-2026-10-03` was merged into `main` at `459c892` with a merge commit, reversing the 3 Oct 2026 "don't merge to main" for this merge only, and then pruned. Kept: the A100 and H100 baseline caveats and audit annotations, the era register (era 4 and native, with the stripped-row refusal from `a1b7801`), the per-head selector, the Llama fixes, the recall pass, splits and kernels, and T1.1's amendments A1 to A9. The split firewall and matched row budgets moved unchanged from `frontier_prereg.py` to `attnbench/analysis/splits_and_budgets.py`. Archived to `docs/archive/`: the estimator-frontier pre-registration, the rest of `frontier_prereg.py`, its plan test, the budget gate and its shell hook. The GPU launchers no longer source the gate, so the gate amendment of 21 Oct 2026 above stays on its local branch, unmerged. Not included: the README count commits and the 16 commits that exist only on the local branch (among them the vendored MInference scorer). T1.1's pre-registration gains a dated note that A6's replication link points to an archived study.
- **22 Oct 2026.** T2.8 resolutions (researcher's decision). (1) A synchronisation carries no host cost: s_fixed(m) already holds the host cost of issuing and completing it, so h_i = 0 there and the recursion refuses anything else. (2) A prefill sequence ends with an explicit closing synchronise, because the ground-truth timer synchronises before it reads the host clock. (3) The recursion without the synchronisation term is built as two named ablations: no synchronisation cost (s_0 = 0, the wait kept) and no synchronisation

wait (the dependency removed). (4) The queue sensitivity rounds each multiple of Q to the nearest whole launch, never below 1, and returns the distinct depths.

- **25 Oct 2026.** T2.9 and T2.10 resolutions (researcher's decision). (1) The sum and the fitted sum stay as written; a fitted sum + s_0, labelled separately, adds the measured synchronisation cost, unfitted. (2) HDBI is sum d / (sum d + sum h), TaxBreak's Eq. 3 (arXiv:2603.12465), computed from this model's components; link costs l are outside it, and so is s_0. (3) The fitted sums minimise the plan's headline error metric, absolute relative error, over their training rows, and every fit reports a condition number. (4) The statistic predicted is the median, since Section 5.3's ground truth reports the median, p90 and p99 and names none; it is a field on every row. (5) The learned predictor keeps host_to_device_ratio, adds the sum of s_0, and computes arithmetic intensity per kernel class and transfer demand relative to link bandwidth analytically, from the model's shape and the recorded payload bytes. (6) Its learning curve runs over 1 to N - 1 training pairings for the N pairings available. (7) LightGBM is an optional extra, pinned to one version.
- **25 Oct 2026.** T1.1 scoring (researcher's decision). P-T4 is scored exactly as written in §3.9 of the archived estimator-frontier pre-registration (final text at `65b8f71`): it predicted that the `authors` table certifies 0 of 2 primary cells, and it certifies 2 of 2, so P-T4 failed. R1 to R4: not scored: comparison run not made. They compare an A100 run on the same 400 ids (the `authors` table on the Triton path, and `sdpa_flash` dense) with Session B's L4 rows; that run was not made and is not scheduled.
- **25 Oct 2026.** Phase 2 and Phase 3 dependencies, T2.10, HDBI and an L4 shakedown (researcher's decision). (1) T3.1 needs every Phase 2 task Done except T2.14's AWS half, T2.23, T2.24, T2.25 and T2.26. (2) T2.2 depends on T2.3. (3) T2.10 is Done, with the six kernel classes for arithmetic intensity and the definition of transfer demand confirmed. (4) HDBI's boundedness thresholds are fitted on the training pairings and recorded at lock. (5) A new task, T2.27: one planned L4 shakedown session, with a checklist of the L4 steps in T2.2 to T2.6, T2.13, T2.16, T2.17 and T2.21.
- **25 Oct 2026.** T2.20 and T2.7 definitions (researcher's decision). (1) A row's provisioning model is the tag that the successful create call writes into the VM's metadata, so the A100's Spot fallback is tagged Spot. It is checked against GCP's `scheduling/preemptible`; if the two disagree, or either is missing, the row records none and the reason. (2) Mask density is the arm's mask as produced, forced blocks included: today's `realised_density`, unchanged. Executed density is measured from the tensor handed to the kernel, not computed from a formula. Both count causally valid blocks times query heads. Dense rows record executed density 1.0 and no mask density. (3) T2.7 reads the Kineto trace for managed-memory use and an Nsight Systems export for page faults. A run checked only from its Kineto trace may claim no managed-memory use, not no page faults. Only the separate nsys-traced pass of the L4 shakedown may claim no page faults, and only for the arms it traced. That pass is never a timing run. It is T2.27's step 10; if nsys is not on the image, it is installed in that session.
- **25 Oct 2026.** Prediction timing (researcher's decision): the timed workload starts at least 60 s after the prediction file and its sha256 are synced, and the analysis allows 60 s of clock skew between the store's clock and the instance's (Section 5.1, T2.11).
- **25 Oct 2026.** Floors (researcher's decision): the resolution floor and the noise floor are fixed at lock from the measured run-to-run spread (Section 5.6, T4.1).
- **25 Oct 2026.** Crossover error (researcher's decision): with the same number of brackets on both sides, each predicted and measured pair is compared in order by containment of the measured bracket in the predicted one, overlap, direction of the sign change, and the shift between their centres in grid steps; otherwise the result is missed, spurious, a different count, or unresolved (Section 5.4, T2.19).
- **25 Oct 2026.** Prediction file key (researcher's decision): each committed prediction is keyed by model, code path, arm, density, context length and batch (Section 5.3, T2.11).
- **25 Oct 2026.** T2.13 records the timestamp of the first timed block, which the analysis's late-prediction check reads (researcher's decision).
- **25 Oct 2026.** New task T2.28 (researcher's decision): density sensitivity, every committed prediction recomputed at plus and minus the measured cross-path density difference, after T2.4 (Section 5.4).
- **25 Oct 2026.** T2.22 (researcher's decision): the dispatcher is no longer needed for T3.1; it becomes a prerequisite of the adversarial reads (T4.3).
- **25 Oct 2026.** HDBI fit rule (researcher's decision): one boundedness threshold, fitted on the training pairings by sign agreement, with ties going to the lower value (Section 5.4, T4.1).
- **25 Oct 2026.** `.item()` and `bool()` (researcher's decision): their payload is zero by definition, so their s_0 is s_fixed (Section 5.1).

- **25 Oct 2026.** Mechanisms (researcher's decision): a blocking host-to-device copy and an event synchronise are synchronisation mechanisms with their own s_fixed, measured under T2.5 (Section 5.1).
- **25 Oct 2026.** `cudaFree` (researcher's decision): an implicit synchronisation inside an allocator call is not costed; it becomes a trace check, and a prefill trace that shows one is flagged (Section 5.1, T2.3).
- **25 Oct 2026.** "Same sequence" (researcher's decision): a strict definition is primary and a looser one secondary, reported beside it; H0 and H2 use the strict one (Section 5.1, T2.3).
- **25 Oct 2026.** T2.5 (researcher's decision): bandwidth is measured in both directions, host to device and device to host.
- **26 Oct 2026.** T2.13 timed region (researcher's decision): every deployable arm's timed region includes its estimator, mask build, copies and synchronisations; the oracle arm may use cached scores and is labelled a non-deployable upper bound; an acceptance test, with a break-test, fails if a deployable arm's scores are computed outside the timed block (Section 5.3, T2.13).
- **26 Oct 2026.** Tie rule (researcher's decision): a predicted tie is "not profitable" (dense); sign agreement now reads it as decision error does; cells inside the resolution floor are not scored and are reported separately (Section 5.4, T2.19).
- **25 Oct 2026.** T2.6 (researcher's decision): the model's Q is the null kernel's.
- **27 Oct 2026.** Substituted positions (researcher's decision): a position the replay graph cannot hold as recorded is priced from an isolated replay of the original operator, and each position's cost source is flagged (Section 5.1, T2.4).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Chunked arms in the structural probe (researcher's decision): three probe lengths, each with at least two chunks; where the result is "different", the full-length structure is recorded on the target with every duration discarded (Section 5.1, T2.18).
- **27 Oct 2026.** The replay-versus-trace bound (researcher's decision) is set at lock from the L4 shakedown's agreement distribution (Section 7, Gate A; T2.4, T4.1).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Compiled variants run one per process in T2.13 (researcher's decision), since Dynamo does not guard compiled code on its own settings: a capture compile after a default compile of the same code reuses the default one (T2.21).
- **27 Oct 2026.** The mean-pool compiled variant is not built (researcher's decision): mean-pool builds its mask in `accuracy/model.py` (`SwappedAttention.forward`), outside any backend, so wrapping a backend in `torch.compile` does not compile its estimator, and compiling it would mean moving the estimator out of the accuracy pipeline (Section 5.5, T2.21).
- **27 Oct 2026.** XAttention kernel call (researcher's decision): `backends/xattention.py` builds the cumulative-length tensors exactly as upstream `Xattention_prefill` does at `e379887`, three device tensors from Python lists, not one shared tensor and a `torch.ones` fill. The outputs are bitwise identical (`tests/test_xattention_backend.py`); the T1.1 results carry the earlier timed-region fingerprint (`docs/vendor_register.md`; T1.1).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Oracle label (correction): "non-deployable upper bound", in the 26 Oct 2026 T2.13 line, was the researcher's own wording, and is replaced by "non-deployable reference (scoring cost outside the timed path)" in Section 5.3 step 7, the T2.13 row and `attnbench/ground_truth.py`. The 4 Oct 2026 decision stands: the oracle arm is an attention-mass reference, not a quality ceiling.
- **27 Oct 2026.** Position limit (researcher's decision): every NIAH row at 32,768 and about a fifth of `qa_1` rows there (19 to 21 of 100 per Session B file) exceed the model's positions, so the `niah_multivalue`/32768 collapse is confounded and is not a finding. Grid rule for future accuracy runs: prompt plus generation cap within 32,768 (Sections 2, 5.3 step 7 and 5.7; `docs/t4_xattention_calibrated.md`, `docs/limitations.md`).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Mask gate and H6, per-arm rule (researcher's decision, before the lock): a failed mask gate (T2.23) removes admissibility on the new code path only from the arms the gate tests, the XAttention arms; every other arm keeps the L4's admissibility, so H6 stays scorable on P2 and P4, with the removed arms named per pairing (Sections 4, 5.1 and 7).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Cells inside the floor (researcher's decision, confirming 26 Oct 2026): a cell whose measured sparse-minus-dense difference is inside the resolution floor stays unscored in decision error and sign agreement, an inadmissible cell included, and is reported separately (Section 5.4, T2.19).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Throttle reasons (researcher's decision): a timed block is flagged by hardware slowdown, software or hardware thermal slowdown, or the hardware power brake; the software power cap, normal on an L4 under load, is recorded on every row and never flags (Section 5.6, T2.13).

- **27 Oct 2026.** First-block stamp, strict rule (researcher's decision, refining the 25 Oct 2026 line): the timestamp the late-prediction check reads is the start of the first clocked block of any kind, the dense control's clocked warm-up forwards included, so a prediction synced during that warm-up is late (T2.13, T2.11).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Precomputed-mask arm (researcher's decision): batch 1 only, since `kernels.bsa_prefill`, its one kernel call, is batch 1; the batch-4 cells have no precomputed-mask arm (Section 5.3 step 7, T2.12).
- **27 Oct 2026.** FA3 (researcher's decision): an FA3 backend, for the H100 dense-baseline selection, is a prerequisite of T6.4; until one exists the H100 record is `complete: false` (Section 5.5, T2.16, T6.4).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Code-path key (researcher's decision, accepting the proposal): a code-path label is the GPU, the implementation, the optimise flag and a hash of the whole definition, without the arm; the nearest-pairing baseline matches model, arm, density, length and batch but not the code path, and the queue sensitivity pairs a sparse cell with the dense cell of its model, length and batch (T2.11, T2.15, T2.19).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Dispatcher ties (researcher's decision, accepting the proposal): ties among equal predicted times, or equal kernel speedups, go to the smaller (arm, density) (Section 5.9, T2.22).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Best-kernel comparator (researcher's decision, accepting the proposal): "always the sparse arm with the best kernel speedup" is one fixed configuration, the one with the best geometric-mean kernel speedup over the points where it is admissible, unscored where a point lacks it (Section 5.9, T2.22).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Builder profile density (researcher's decision, accepting the proposal): the reference mask builder is profiled at density 0.5 (T2.2).
- **27 Oct 2026.** Builder Python-overhead share (researcher's decision, restating the 19 Oct 2026 line): Sections 1 and 2 state it per instrument, about 94% under `cProfile` and about 53% under `torch.profiler` (lower bound 28%), from development-machine profiles at 32768 tokens, not banked. `cProfile` counts the builder's tensor element writes as Python time and `torch.profiler` counts them as operators; T2.2 banks both on the target host (Sections 1 and 2, T2.2).
- **28 Oct 2026.** FA3 build (researcher's decisions): the pin is the archived `e9515d5d` only if it has a documented successful build on this stack, otherwise the latest tagged release, never `main` (no such build is documented, so v2.8.3.post2, commit 49774b31); the build machine is `n2-standard-16`, on-demand, `us-central1`, with a hard cap sized from the planning rate; no third-party wheel (T6.4, `docs/t64_fa3_plan.md` Section 8).
- **28 Oct 2026.** FA3 restricted build (researcher's decision, after the first build was killed for memory): head dimension 128, forward, bf16 and fp16; paged KV, append KV, split KV, softcap, local attention, FP8 and backward compiled out; the flags recorded in the wheel's manifest and in the code identity; the backend refuses other head dims. Build settings: `n2-standard-16`, 15 GB per job, 1 s memory samples, 3 h cap, halt at 150 minutes, build deadline 120 minutes, and the VM halts itself when the build ends (T6.4).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Sync gap (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): one source for the 60 s gap and skew (`commit.REQUIRED_SYNC_GAP_S`); every session runner waits the gap plus 30 s (`PLANNED_SYNC_WAIT_S`), and no runner or library module holds the number as a literal (a test scans for it); a start must be more than 60 s after the sync (Section 5.1, T2.11). Restates the 25 Oct 2026 line, which said "at least".
- **31 Oct 2026.** Training set (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): the committed baselines' training pairings must equal the pairings banked before the prediction, in both directions; a pairing banked within the allowed skew of the write is refused as unorderable (Section 5.4, T2.11).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Scoring (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): scoring reads only predictions loaded through `load_committed` with a checked sync time (K9; T2.11, T2.15).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Throttle detection (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): the session's controls refuse a counters-only sampler and any flag set missing hardware slowdown, either thermal slowdown or the hardware power brake; the software power cap is recorded and cannot be chosen to flag (Section 5.3, T2.13; restates the 27 Oct 2026 line).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Ground-truth rows (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): every row carries context length, batch, mask density, executed density and builder kind ("cpu" or "gpu"; none for dense), checked by `gt_schema` in the harness and the readers. The builder kind is where the row's timed mask construction runs, and the harness holds it to the probe's events; the oracle builds its mask from cached scores on the host inside the timed block, so it is "cpu" and no further value is needed (Section 5.3, T2.13, T2.20, T7.1).

- **31 Oct 2026.** K2 control (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): the dense control is checked against the choice recorded for the same card, context length and batch as the prediction key (Section 5.5, T2.16).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Strict "same sequence" (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): the ordered operation class, stream, blocking or not and payload class; kernel names ignored. The scored pairings per hypothesis are printed in the lock table (Section 5.1, T2.3, T4.1).
- **31 Oct 2026.** The implicit `cudaFree` wait is flagged, not refused, and the flag reaches the banked record; the blocking copy from the host and the event synchronise are no longer marked unpriced (T2.3).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Mask bank (researcher's decision, confirming the proposal of 29 Oct 2026): the manifest's density and causal fields are hashed and rechecked against the masks on load (T2.4).
- **31 Oct 2026.** T4.1 additions (researcher's decision): the list names the learned predictor's features and hyperparameters, the K2 correctness tolerance, the head-type criterion, the floors quantile, the rerun budget and the throttle set, and also the payload class edges, the prompt-set hash and tokenizer version, and the realised-length key rule. T4.1 now also depends on T1.5 and T1.3. The looser "same sequence" definition stays an open item (Section 5.1, T2.3, T4.1).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Related work (researcher's decision, applying `docs/related_work_verified.md`): KernelSight-LM's Eq. 4 and its host-constant claim are restated as the paper has them; the null-kernel comparison figures are named with their tools; The Sparse Frontier's stated unknown is quoted; MInference, FlexPrefill, SpargeAttn, CompactAttention, the SKIP paper and The Sparse Frontier have their claims verified against full text, which is not the researcher's own reading; XAttention, KernelSight-LM, TaxBreak and CTFusion stay to be read in full by the researcher; the XAttention venue is shown as arXiv, unconfirmed (Sections 3, 5.4, 5.6, 10, T7.2).
- **31 Oct 2026.** AWS (researcher's decisions of 28 Oct 2026, recorded here): last AWS launch date 20 Dec 2026, provisional; on-demand only; machine sizes as in Section 5.2; proposed planning rates recorded there; each launch's cost cap is its planning rate times its planned hours times 1.5 (Section 5.2, Section 6 rule 13, T5.1).
- **31 Oct 2026.** Plan audit (researcher's decision, applying `docs/plan_audit.md` as one batch): the edits with no open choice are applied: A1, A2, A6, B3, B5, D1, D2, D5 to D11, E1, E2, E4, E6, F1, F2, F5 and G3. Left for a decision: A3, A4, A5, A7, B1, B2, B4, B6, D3, D4, D12, E3, E5, E7, F3, F4, G4 and C4 to C8 (`docs/plan_audit.md` keeps their wording).

## Appendix B. Glossary

**Arm:** one way of producing masks (or dense attention), timed and scored identically. **Estimator:** the part of an arm that decides which blocks to keep. **Density:** fraction of blocks kept; *executed* density can differ from *mask* density after unions. **Crossover:** the grid bracket in which the sign of sparse minus dense time changes on a pairing (Section 5.4); there may be none or two. **Noise floor:** the between-session spread of end-to-end time (P1 repeats). **Resolution floor:** the smallest sparse-minus-dense difference interpreted, set from the within-session spread of that difference. **Regret:** how much slower the dispatcher's chosen configuration is than the best measured admissible one. **Graph break:** a point where `torch.compile` stops one compiled graph and falls back to Python before starting the next. **Pairing:** one host CPU platform with one GPU model on one provider. **Mask-rule era:** a period during which the mask rule was unchanged; results from different eras are not pooled.